Catechism.

YEAR 2 · UNIT 16 · DAYS 603-633

The New Covenant Inaugurated: Luke

Luke 1-24

The universal scope of redemption. Good news for the poor, the outcast, and all nations.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost."

LUKE 19:10

Praise (113, 116, 117) and trust under pressure (27, 28, 31, 41, 55) beside Luke.

UNIT 16

In this unit

WEEK 87

603	Luke 1:1-80	*Reading*
604	Luke 2:1-52	*Reading*
605	Luke 3:1-4:13	*Reading*
606	Luke 4:14-5:39	*Reading*
607	Luke 6:1-49	*Reading*
608	Psalm 113	*Psalm*
609	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 88

610	Psalm 116	*Psalm*
611	Psalm 117	*Psalm*
612	Luke 7:1-8:21	*Reading*
613	Luke 8:22-9:50	*Reading*
614	Luke 9:51-11:13	*Reading*
615	Luke 11:14-13:21	*Reading*
616	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 89

617	Psalm 27	*Psalm*
618	Psalm 28	*Psalm*
619	Psalm 31:1-18	*Psalm*
620	Luke 13:22-15:32	*Reading*
621	Luke 16:1-17:37	*Reading*
622	Luke 18:1-19:27	*Reading*
623	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 90

624	Luke 19:28-21:38	*Reading*

625	Psalm 31:19-24	*Psalm*
626	Psalm 41	*Psalm*
627	Psalm 55:1-23	*Psalm*
628	Luke 22:1-46	*Reading*
629	Luke 22:47-23:25	*Reading*
630	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 91

631	Luke 23:26-56	*Reading*
632	Luke 24:1-53	*Reading*
633	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 603 · WEEK 87

Luke 1:1-80

The promise; the Magnificat; the Benedictus

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 80 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 1:1-80. Luke begins with a careful preface, then tells of two miraculous births: John to an old priest and his wife, and Jesus to a young virgin. Read Mary's song (1:46-55) and Zechariah's song (1:68-79) aloud, slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Luke was a physician and a traveling companion of Paul. He was not an eyewitness, and he says so. He investigated everything carefully and wrote an orderly account for a man named Theophilus, so that he might know the certainty of what he had been taught. Luke also wrote the book of Acts, and together the two books make up about a quarter of the New Testament. Luke is especially interested in the Holy Spirit, in prayer, in women, in the poor and outcast, and in good news that reaches the Gentiles. The Gospel opens in the temple in Jerusalem, in the dusty hill country, and in a small town of Galilee, and it begins with songs.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "It seemed good to me also, having followed all things closely for some time past, to write an orderly account for you, most excellent Theophilus" (1:3).
2. "And he will be filled with the Holy Spirit, even from his mother's womb" (1:15).
3. "The Holy Spirit will come upon you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you; therefore the child to be born will be called holy, the Son of God" (1:35).
4. "For nothing will be impossible with God" (1:37).
5. "Behold, I am the servant of the Lord; let it be to me according to your word" (1:38).
6. "My soul magnifies the Lord, and my spirit rejoices in God my Savior" (1:46-47).

7. “He has brought down the mighty from their thrones and exalted those of humble estate; he has filled the hungry with good things, and the rich he has sent away empty” (1:52-53).

8. “Blessed be the Lord God of Israel, for he has visited and redeemed his people” (1:68).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Luke tells us at the outset what kind of book this is. It is history, researched and arranged with care. The faith is not built on rumor. It is built on events that happened, which witnesses saw and Luke investigated.

The first scene is in the temple. An old priest named Zechariah is told that his barren wife Elizabeth will bear a son who will go before the Lord “in the spirit and power of Elijah,” to turn hearts and prepare a people. Zechariah doubts and is made silent. The Gospel begins where the Old Testament ended, with Malachi’s promise of Elijah, and with silence broken.

Then the angel comes to Mary, a young woman in Nazareth, and Luke gives us one of the great statements of the incarnation. The Holy Spirit will come upon her, and the child will be the Son of God. Mary’s response is a model of faith: “Let it be to me according to your word.” She does not understand how, but she trusts.

Mary visits Elizabeth, and the unborn John leaps. Then Mary sings the Magnificat, which is built from the songs of the Old Testament, especially Hannah’s. It is a song about reversal. God lifts up the lowly, feeds the hungry, and sends the rich away empty. It is also a song about promise kept: God has helped his servant Israel, “as he spoke to our fathers, to Abraham and to his offspring forever.” The salvation Mary sings about is both spiritual and concrete, and it will turn the world’s order upside down.

The chapter ends with Zechariah’s song, the Benedictus. His tongue is loosed, and he is filled with the Spirit and praises God for visiting and redeeming his people, for raising up a horn of salvation in the house of David, and for remembering his holy covenant. He closes with the image of the sunrise from on high, giving light to those in darkness and guiding feet into the way of peace. A new day is dawning.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 18:14 asked, “Is anything too hard for the LORD?” and Luke 1:37 answers it. 1 Samuel 2:1-10 is Hannah’s song, which stands behind Mary’s. Malachi 4:5-6 promised Elijah, and Luke 1:17 shows John fulfilling it. 2 Samuel 7:12-16 is the promise to David that Gabriel

echoes in 1:32-33. Isaiah 7:14 and 9:6-7 are in the background. John 1:14 says the Word became flesh. Galatians 4:4 says God sent forth his Son, born of woman.

STEP 6

Application

Read the Magnificat aloud. Which line speaks to you most, and why?

Think of a promise from God that seems impossible. Pray Mary's answer: "Let it be to me according to your word."

Notice how many people in this chapter are ordinary and humble. Thank God that he works through those the world overlooks.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Say to God, "Let it be to me according to your word," and tell him what that means for you.
- Thank him for keeping his promises to Abraham and David.
- Praise him, as Mary did, in your own words.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 87

"For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord."

LUKE 2:11

DAY 604 · WEEK 87

Luke 2:1-52

The birth; the shepherds; Simeon and Anna; the boy Jesus

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 52 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 2:1-52. Luke gives the birth of Jesus with historical care and quiet wonder. Notice who hears the news first, and notice the last verse of the chapter.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Luke sets the birth of Jesus in the larger world: Caesar Augustus, a census, Quirinius governing Syria. The emperor is moving millions of people with a decree, yet the real King is being born in a stable to a peasant couple. Luke wants us to see the contrast between earthly power and heavenly power. Bethlehem is the city of David, so the birth fulfills the promise that the Messiah would come from David's line.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And she gave birth to her firstborn son and wrapped him in swaddling cloths and laid him in a manger, because there was no place for them in the inn" (2:7).
2. "And in the same region there were shepherds out in the field, keeping watch over their flock by night" (2:8).
3. "Fear not, for behold, I bring you good news of great joy that will be for all the people" (2:10).
4. "For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord" (2:11).
5. "Glory to God in the highest, and on earth peace among those with whom he is pleased!" (2:14).
6. "But Mary treasured up all these things, pondering them in her heart" (2:19).

7. “For my eyes have seen your salvation… a light for revelation to the Gentiles, and for glory to your people Israel” (2:30-32).

8. “And Jesus increased in wisdom and in stature and in favor with God and man” (2:52).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The birth is told simply. There is no room for them in the inn, and the Savior is laid in a feeding trough. The Son of God enters the world in poverty and obscurity.

The first announcement is not to the powerful but to shepherds, who were low on the social ladder and often distrusted. An angel appears, and the glory of the Lord shines around them. The news is “good news of great joy that will be for all the people,” and the titles in verse 11 are rich. The child is a Savior, the Christ, and the Lord. A baby in a manger is all three. The shepherds go in haste, find the child as they were told, and return glorifying and praising God. They are the first evangelists.

When the child is brought to the temple, two old people recognize him. Simeon had been promised by the Spirit that he would not die before seeing the Lord’s Christ. He takes the child in his arms and sings: his eyes have seen salvation, prepared in the presence of all peoples, “a light for revelation to the Gentiles, and for glory to your people Israel.” This is the universal note of Luke. Simeon also tells Mary that a sword will pierce her own soul, because the child will cause the rising and falling of many and be opposed. Joy and sorrow are linked from the start. Anna, an elderly prophetess who never left the temple, gives thanks and tells everyone who was waiting for the redemption of Jerusalem.

The chapter ends with the twelve-year-old Jesus in the temple, listening to teachers and asking questions. When his parents find him, he says, “Did you not know that I must be in my Father’s house?” Already he knows who his Father is. And yet he goes home and is subject to them. The Son of God grows up, with all the ordinary stages of human life.

STEP 5

Connection

Micah 5:2 names Bethlehem as the place of the ruler’s birth. Isaiah 9:6 says to us a child is born. Isaiah 49:6 speaks of a light for the nations. Luke 2:34-35 points ahead to the cross. Philippians 2:6-8 describes the Son who emptied himself and took the form of a servant. 2 Corinthians 8:9 says that though he was rich, yet for your sake he became poor. Hebrews 2:14 says he shared in our flesh and blood.

STEP 6

Application

Take time to listen to the angels' words as if they were spoken to you: "Fear not… unto you is born this day a Savior."

Ponder, like Mary, one thing from this week's reading. Hold it in your heart and pray over it.

Be like the shepherds and tell someone the good news of great joy this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for sending his Son in humility.

Tell him what it is like to hear that the news of his birth is for all people.

Ask him to teach you to treasure it, as Mary did.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 87

"For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord."

LUKE 2:11

DAY 605 · WEEK 87

Luke 3:1-4:13

John; baptism; genealogy; the temptation

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 51 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 3:1-4:13. John preaches, Jesus is baptized and prays, a genealogy runs back to Adam, and the devil tests him in the wilderness. Compare this with Matthew's accounts, and notice what Luke adds.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Luke again places the story in history, naming Tiberius, Pilate, Herod, and the high priests. Into that world, the word of God comes to John in the wilderness. Luke's account of John is fuller in some ways than Matthew's, with specific advice for the crowds, tax collectors, and soldiers. His genealogy of Jesus runs backward to Adam rather than forward from Abraham, which fits Luke's concern for all people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The word of God came to John the son of Zechariah in the wilderness" (3:2).
2. "And all flesh shall see the salvation of God" (3:6).
3. "Bear fruits in keeping with repentance" (3:8).
4. "Whoever has two tunics is to share with him who has none, and whoever has food is to do likewise" (3:11).
5. "Now when all the people were baptized, and when Jesus also had been baptized and was praying, the heavens were opened" (3:21).
6. "The son of Adam, the son of God" (3:38).
7. "And Jesus, full of the Holy Spirit, returned from the Jordan and was led by the Spirit in the wilderness" (4:1).

8 “And when the devil had ended every temptation, he departed from him until an opportune time” (4:13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Luke 3:6 quotes Isaiah 40 and goes a step further than the other Gospels, ending with “all flesh shall see the salvation of God.” This is Luke’s theme. John’s message is practical. When the crowds ask what to do, he tells them to share. Tax collectors are told to collect no more than they are authorized. Soldiers are to stop extorting. Repentance has a concrete shape: generosity and honesty.

At the baptism, Luke alone notes that Jesus was praying. This is the first of many times in Luke that prayer precedes a decisive moment in Jesus’ life. While he prays, the Spirit descends in bodily form and the Father speaks: “You are my beloved Son; with you I am well pleased.” The Trinity is present: the Father speaks, the Son prays, and the Spirit descends.

The genealogy that follows runs from Jesus back through David, Abraham, Noah, and finally to Adam, “the son of God.” Jesus is the second Adam, and his story is humanity’s story. Where Adam failed in a garden, he will succeed in a wilderness.

In the temptation, Luke notes that Jesus was full of the Holy Spirit and led by the Spirit. He is hungry after forty days. The devil first tempts him to turn stones into bread, then offers him all the kingdoms of the world, and finally takes him to the pinnacle of the temple and quotes Scripture to him. Jesus answers each time with a verse from Deuteronomy. Luke reverses the order of the second and third temptations from Matthew, ending in Jerusalem, where the story will end. The devil departs “until an opportune time,” a hint that the real battle is still ahead.

The Son of God does not use his power to serve himself. He relies on the word of God and the Spirit, as we must.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 40:3-5 is the passage John fulfills. Genesis 3 is the first temptation, and Romans 5:12-19 contrasts Adam and Christ. 1 Corinthians 15:45 calls Christ the last Adam. Hebrews 2:18 says that because he himself has suffered when tempted, he is able to help those who are being tempted. Luke 22:3 shows the devil’s return at the “opportune time,” when Satan enters Judas. Ephesians 6:17 describes the sword of the Spirit.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what fruit in keeping with repentance would look like for you this week. Be as practical as John was.

When temptation comes, answer it with Scripture, as Jesus did. Choose a verse to carry.

Pray before big decisions, as Jesus did at his baptism.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus, the last Adam, for resisting where the first fell.

Ask him to fill you with his Spirit.

Tell him where you are being tempted.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 87

"For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord."

LUKE 2:11

DAY 606 · WEEK 87

Luke 4:14-5:39

Nazareth; first disciples; controversies

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 72 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 4:14-5:39. Jesus preaches in Nazareth, is rejected, begins to heal and call disciples, and meets his first controversies. Read 4:18-21 slowly. It is the mission statement of the whole Gospel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus returns to Galilee in the power of the Spirit. He goes to the synagogue in Nazareth, his hometown, as was his custom, and he is handed the scroll of Isaiah. The reading he chooses is from Isaiah 61, which describes the anointed one who will bring good news to the poor. What he says next, and how the people respond, sets the pattern for his ministry: great grace and great opposition.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor” (4:18).
2. “He has sent me to proclaim liberty to the captives and recovering of sight to the blind, to set at liberty those who are oppressed” (4:18).
3. “Today this Scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing” (4:21).
4. “Truly, I say to you, no prophet is acceptable in his hometown” (4:24).
5. “But he would withdraw to desolate places and pray” (5:16).
6. “Depart from me, for I am a sinful man, O Lord” (5:8).
7. “Do not be afraid; from now on you will be catching men” (5:10).
8. “I have not come to call the righteous but sinners to repentance” (5:32).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Nazareth, Jesus reads the words of Isaiah and sits down, as a teacher does. Every eye is fastened on him. “Today this Scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing.” That is a stunning claim. He is the anointed one of Isaiah 61: the Spirit is upon him, and he brings good news to the poor, freedom to captives, sight to the blind, and release to the oppressed. The “year of the Lord’s favor” is the jubilee, the great year of release.

The people at first marvel at his gracious words. But then he reminds them that God sent Elijah to a widow in Sidon and Elisha to heal Naaman the Syrian, both Gentiles, while Israel’s own needy were passed over. The hometown crowd erupts in fury and tries to throw him off a cliff. The pattern is set. The good news will go to outsiders, and many insiders will reject it. Jesus passes through the midst of them and goes away.

In Capernaum, he teaches with authority, casts out a demon, heals Peter’s mother-in-law, and heals many at sundown. Luke notes that he withdraws to pray in desolate places. Even when crowds clamor for him, he keeps to his mission: “I must preach the good news of the kingdom of God to the other towns also; for I was sent for this purpose.”

The miraculous catch of fish leads to Peter’s confession. Seeing the power of Jesus, Peter does not rejoice but falls at his knees, saying, “Depart from me, for I am a sinful man.” The presence of holiness exposes sin. Jesus does not depart. He says, “Do not be afraid,” and calls Peter to follow. Peter, James, and John leave everything.

Then come the first controversies: Jesus forgives and heals a paralyzed man, calls Levi the tax collector, and eats with sinners. The Pharisees grumble, and Jesus answers: “Those who are well have no need of a physician, but those who are sick.” He then speaks of new wine in new wineskins. The new covenant cannot be poured into the old forms.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 61:1-2 and 58:6 stand behind Jesus’ reading. Leviticus 25 describes the year of jubilee. 1 Kings 17:8-16 and 2 Kings 5 are the Old Testament stories Jesus cites. Isaiah 6:5 shows the prophet’s cry, “Woe is me!” before the holy God. Mark 2:17 has the parallel on the physician. 2 Corinthians 5:17 says that if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. John 1:11 says he came to his own, and his own people did not receive him.

STEP 6

Application

Read Isaiah 61:1-2 slowly and ask where Jesus has done this in your life.

Notice Jesus' habit of slipping away to pray. Plan a regular time and place for it.

Like Peter, bring your sinfulness to Jesus without hiding it, and hear him say, "Do not be afraid."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for bringing good news to the poor, liberty to captives, and sight to the blind.

Tell him what you need him to set free in you.

Ask him to teach you to follow.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 87

"For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord."

LUKE 2:11

DAY 607 · WEEK 87

Luke 6:1-49

Sabbath disputes; the Twelve; the Sermon on the Plain

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 49 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 6:1-49. Sabbath disputes, the choosing of the Twelve after a night of prayer, and the Sermon on the Plain. Compare it with the Sermon on the Mount from Matthew 5 to 7.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Opposition from the religious leaders grows over the Sabbath. Then Jesus spends a night in prayer on the mountain, chooses twelve apostles, and comes down to a level place to teach a great crowd. The Sermon on the Plain is shorter than Matthew's version and focused on a few things: blessings and woes, love for enemies, mercy, and obedience. It is likely the same teaching given on another occasion, or a summary.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The Son of Man is lord of the Sabbath" (6:5).
2. "In these days he went out to the mountain to pray, and all night he continued in prayer to God" (6:12).
3. "Blessed are you who are poor, for yours is the kingdom of God" (6:20).
4. "But woe to you who are rich, for you have received your consolation" (6:24).
5. "But I say to you who hear, Love your enemies, do good to those who hate you" (6:27).
6. "Be merciful, even as your Father is merciful" (6:36).
7. "Why do you call me Lord, Lord, and not do what I tell you?" (6:46).
8. "But the one who hears and does not do is like a man who built a house on the ground without a foundation" (6:49).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Sabbath conflicts show what is at stake. The disciples pluck grain, and Jesus defends them, citing David, and declares himself lord of the Sabbath. On another Sabbath, he heals a man's withered hand, and asks, "Is it lawful on the Sabbath to do good or to do harm, to save life or to destroy it?" The Pharisees are filled with fury.

Then comes the night of prayer. Before choosing the Twelve, Jesus spends the whole night in prayer. A major decision is preceded by deep communion with the Father. He names twelve, including Judas Iscariot, "who became a traitor." The Twelve are the foundation of the renewed Israel.

On the plain, with a great crowd, he gives the Beatitudes with a difference. Luke records four blessings and four woes. "Blessed are you who are poor… hungry… weep… hated." And "woe to you who are rich… full… laugh… spoken well of." These are not general wishes. Jesus speaks to his disciples, and he puts the reversal clearly: those who look secure now may be empty later, and those who suffer for him will be rewarded.

The heart of the sermon is love for enemies. "Love your enemies, do good to those who hate you, bless those who curse you, pray for those who abuse you." This is not just a rule for sentiment but for action: give, lend, and expect nothing back. The standard is the character of God himself: "Be merciful, even as your Father is merciful." The Father is kind even to the ungrateful and the evil.

Then come warnings about judging, the log in the eye, and a tree known by its fruit. The sermon ends with the two builders. The one who hears and does is like the one who dug deep and laid the foundation on rock. The difference is obedience, and the question is pointed: "Why do you call me Lord, Lord, and not do what I tell you?"

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 5 to 7 is the longer Sermon on the Mount, and you read it in Unit 15. Psalm 1 is the background to the two ways. 1 Samuel 21:1-6 is the story of David's eating the bread. Romans 12:14-21 repeats Jesus' teaching on enemies. 1 Peter 2:21-23 says Christ left us an example. James 1:22 says to be doers of the word. Ephesians 4:32 says to forgive as God in Christ forgave you.

STEP 6

Application

Pray through the night, or at least for an hour, before a significant decision.

Choose one enemy or difficult person and do something good for them this week, without expecting anything back.

Ask the Lord's own question of yourself: do I call him Lord and do what he says?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for being Lord of the Sabbath.
- Thank him for praying all night before choosing his apostles.
- Ask him to help you do what he says, not only hear.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 87

"For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord."

LUKE 2:11

DAY 608 · WEEK 87

Psalm 113

He raises the poor from the dust, the Magnificat's psalm

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 113. This is the first psalm in the Hallel (Psalms 113 to 118). It praises the God who raises the poor from the dust, and it echoes Hannah's song and Mary's song. Read it beside the Magnificat.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 113 opens a group of six psalms sung at Passover and other great feasts. It is short and structured as three stanzas: God's name is to be praised, God is high above all nations, and yet he stoops to lift the needy. It stands behind Hannah's song in 1 Samuel 2 and Mary's song in Luke 1. Reading it just after Luke 1 and 2 shows where Mary found her words.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD! Praise, O servants of the LORD, praise the name of the LORD!" (v. 1).
2. "Blessed be the name of the LORD from this time forth and forevermore!" (v. 2).
3. "From the rising of the sun to its setting, the name of the LORD is to be praised!" (v. 3).
4. "The LORD is high above all nations, and his glory above the heavens!" (v. 4).
5. "Who is like the LORD our God, who is seated on high" (v. 5).
6. "Who looks far down on the heavens and the earth?" (v. 6).
7. "He raises the poor from the dust and lifts the needy from the ash heap" (v. 7).
8. "He gives the barren woman a home, making her the joyous mother of children" (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with praise and its scope grows wider with each verse. First the servants of the LORD, then all time ("from this time forth and forevermore"), then all space ("from the rising of the sun to its setting"). The name of the LORD is to be praised everywhere and always.

Then the question: "Who is like the LORD our God?" He is seated on high, above all nations and above the heavens. In the ancient world, the great gods were high and distant. But here is the surprise. This God "looks far down on the heavens and the earth." He is so high that even the heavens are far below him, and yet he looks down and sees the lowly.

What does he do? He raises the poor from the dust. He lifts the needy from the ash heap and seats them with princes, even the princes of his people. And he gives the barren woman a home and a family. This is the pattern of the Bible's story: Sarah, Rebekah, Rachel, Hannah, and Elizabeth. Again and again the barren woman receives a child, and God's purposes advance through those who seemed least likely.

Now read Luke 1 again. Mary sings, "He has brought down the mighty from their thrones and exalted those of humble estate." She draws on this psalm and on Hannah's song. Elizabeth, barren, has a son in her old age. Mary herself is of humble estate, and she carries the Son of God. The one who raises the poor from the dust has come down in person. The incarnation is the greatest instance of the psalm: the God who is high above all stoops lower than anyone could expect, to a manger and a cross, and lifts people up.

STEP 5

Connection

1 Samuel 2:1-10 is Hannah's song, and Luke 1:46-55 is Mary's. Isaiah 57:15 says God dwells in the high and holy place and also with the contrite and lowly. Philippians 2:5-11 describes Christ's descent and exaltation. Ephesians 2:4-6 says God raised us up with Christ and seated us with him in the heavenly places. James 4:6 says God gives grace to the humble. Matthew 26:30 says that after the Last Supper they sang a hymn, likely the Hallel.

STEP 6

Application

Praise God today from the "rising of the sun to its setting." Make it a thread through your day.

Think of someone overlooked or lowly. Ask how you might lift them up.

Thank God that he lifted you from the dust through Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God for raising the poor from the dust.

Tell him what he has lifted you from.

Bless his name now and forevermore.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 87

"For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord."

LUKE 2:11

DAY 609 · WEEK 87

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Luke 2:11 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord."

LUKE 2:11

REST

Meditation

An angel says these words to shepherds in the dark, on a hillside outside Bethlehem. It is the message at the center of the Christmas story and of the Gospel.

"For unto you." The news is personal. The angel does not say, "For the world in general." He says, "For you." The first people to hear it were common workers in the fields. The gospel comes to people where they are, and it is addressed to each of us.

"Is born this day." The word "today" is one of Luke's favorites. Salvation is not only a future hope. It has arrived in time and space, on a particular day, in a real town. God has acted in history.

"In the city of David." The Savior comes in the line of the great king. Every promise about David's throne is being fulfilled in this child.

“A Savior.” The word means rescuer. He is born not just to teach or to inspire but to save. Matthew told us he would save his people from their sins. Luke says that he is a Savior for “all the people.”

“Who is Christ the Lord.” Christ means the anointed king. Lord means the one who rules, and it is the word the Greek Old Testament used for God himself. The baby in the manger is God’s anointed king and God himself.

When you feel that the gospel is too big or too distant, say this verse. It was spoken first to shepherds, and it is for you.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the Gospel of Luke. You read Luke’s careful preface, the promise of two births, and the songs of Mary and Zechariah, which celebrate God’s keeping of every promise. You saw the Savior born in a manger and heard the angels announce good news to shepherds. You watched Simeon and Anna recognize him in the temple. You followed John’s call to repentance, Jesus’ baptism and temptation, and his first sermon in Nazareth, where he read Isaiah and said, “Today this Scripture has been fulfilled.” You saw him call sinners, eat with outcasts, and spend a whole night in prayer before choosing the Twelve. The Sermon on the Plain called you to love your enemies and build on the rock. Psalm 113 gave you the words behind the Magnificat: the God who is high above all stoops to raise the poor from the dust.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Luke records that the angels’ first announcement was to shepherds. What does that tell you about the kind of people the gospel is for, and how might it change who you notice this week?

Jesus read Isaiah 61 in Nazareth and said, “Today this Scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing.” How does Jesus fulfill the good news for the poor, the captives, and the blind?

Mary said, “Let it be to me according to your word.” Where do you most need to say that to God right now?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that to us a Savior is born.

Thank him that the good news is for all people.

Let yourself rest in it.

DAY 610 · WEEK 88

Psalm 116

I love the LORD, because he has heard my voice

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Psalm · 19 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 116. This is a song of thanks from someone who was near death and was saved. It is part of the Hallel, sung at Passover. Read it aloud as a personal testimony.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 116 is a thanksgiving psalm. The singer has cried out in deep trouble and God has answered, and now he comes to the congregation to keep his vows. The psalm is anonymous, but it is easy to imagine David or Hezekiah behind it. Because it belongs to the Hallel, Jesus and his disciples almost certainly sang it on the night before he died, a few hours before Gethsemane.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I love the LORD, because he has heard my voice and my pleas for mercy" (v. 1).
2. "Because he inclined his ear to me, therefore I will call on him as long as I live" (v. 2).
3. "The snares of death encompassed me; the pangs of Sheol laid hold on me; I suffered distress and anguish" (v. 3).
4. "Gracious is the LORD, and righteous; our God is merciful" (v. 5).
5. "The LORD preserves the simple; when I was brought low, he saved me" (v. 6).
6. "For you have delivered my soul from death, my eyes from tears, my feet from stumbling" (v. 8).
7. "What shall I render to the LORD for all his benefits to me?" (v. 12).
8. "Precious in the sight of the LORD is the death of his saints" (v. 15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with love: “I love the LORD.” The reason is not a general feeling but a specific answer. He heard my voice. The God of the universe bent down his ear to a person in need. The psalmist concludes that he will call on God for as long as he lives.

Then he tells his story. Death had wrapped around him like a snare. Distress and anguish found him. In that darkness he called, “O LORD, I pray, deliver my soul!” and the LORD answered. The character of the God who answers is given in verse 5: gracious, righteous, and merciful. These three words belong together. His grace is never at odds with his justice.

He says he was “brought low,” and the LORD saved him. Now he can rest: “Return, O my soul, to your rest, for the LORD has dealt bountifully with you.” Deliverance from death, tears, and stumbling is the work of God alone.

Then comes one of the great questions of the Psalter: “What shall I render to the LORD for all his benefits to me?” The answer is not a payment, since no one can repay God. It is worship and trust: “I will lift up the cup of salvation and call on the name of the LORD.” He will pay his vows in the presence of all the people.

Verse 15 is for the grieving: “Precious in the sight of the LORD is the death of his saints.” Death is not meaningless to God. Every believer who dies is watched over with care.

Read this psalm beside the Last Supper. Jesus lifted a cup that night, and the psalm was in his mouth. He would soon drink a cup of suffering so that we might receive the cup of salvation. The cry of the psalmist became the cry of Jesus, and the deliverance he sang about was won in his death and resurrection.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 18:4-6 describes similar cords of death. Matthew 26:30 and Mark 14:26 say they sang a hymn before going out. Luke 22:17-20 describes the cup at the Supper. 1 Corinthians 10:16 speaks of the cup of blessing. Romans 12:1 offers the answer to “What shall I render?” Hebrews 2:14-15 says Christ delivered those enslaved by fear of death. Revelation 14:13 speaks of those who die in the Lord.

STEP 6

Application

Tell the story of a time God answered you. Write it down or tell it to someone.

Answer verse 12 for yourself. What will you render to the LORD this week? Make it concrete.

If you have lost a believer, rest in verse 15. Their death is precious to the LORD.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God that you love him and why.
- Thank him for delivering you from death and tears.
- Ask him what you can render to him for all his benefits.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 88

"If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me."

LUKE 9:23

DAY 611 · WEEK 88

Psalm 117

Praise the LORD, all nations, the shortest psalm; widest vision

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Psalm · 2 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 117. It has only two verses. Read it three times, slowly, once for each phrase of the call, and notice how much is packed into so few words.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 117 is the shortest chapter in the Bible and the middle chapter of the Bible's chapters, by number. It is part of the Hallel, sung at the feasts. In two verses it calls the whole world to praise the God of Israel, and gives the reason. Paul quotes it in Romans 15 to show that the Gentiles were always meant to glorify God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD" (v. 1).
2. "all nations" (v. 1).
3. "Extol him" (v. 1).
4. "all peoples" (v. 1).
5. "great is his steadfast love" (v. 2).
6. "toward us" (v. 2).
7. "the faithfulness of the LORD" (v. 2).
8. "endures forever" (v. 2).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is short, but it is wide. The call is not to Israel only but to "all nations" and "all peoples." Under the old covenant, God's saving work was centered on one nation. But from the beginning, the aim was the world. God promised Abraham that in him all the families of the earth would be blessed. The psalmists often sing of a day when the nations will bow. Psalm 117 states it as a command: praise the LORD, all of you.

Notice the reason: "For great is his steadfast love toward us." The word "us" is Israel, the people who knew God's covenant love. The nations are called to praise him because of what he has done for his people. When the nations see the LORD's love to Israel, they are drawn to worship. And the Gentiles who come in are included in the "us" by faith.

The two characteristics that the psalm names are the two that run through the whole Old Testament: steadfast love and faithfulness. They were revealed to Moses on Sinai ("abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness") and they are the foundation of the covenant. God does not just love; he keeps his word. His faithfulness "endures forever."

This is the Bible in miniature: the LORD's love for his people, his faithfulness through time, and his purpose for the world. Luke's Gospel carries the same note. Simeon sang of a light for the Gentiles. John the Baptist quoted Isaiah, "All flesh shall see the salvation of God." Jesus will praise the faith of a Roman centurion. The psalm that told the nations to sing is being fulfilled in the church today, as people from every tribe and language come to Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 12:3 promised blessing to all the families of the earth. Exodus 34:6 states the LORD's character. Psalm 67 prays that all the nations praise him. Isaiah 49:6 speaks of salvation to the end of the earth. Luke 2:32 echoes it. Romans 15:11 quotes this psalm. Revelation 7:9 pictures a great multitude from every nation, praising God.

STEP 6

Application

Read the psalm aloud in a different voice each time: quietly, with joy, and as a shout.

Pray for one nation or people group by name today, that they would praise the LORD.

Memorize the two verses. They are the shortest way to remember what God's love and faithfulness mean.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God with all the nations in your own words.

Thank him for his great steadfast love toward us.

Pray for the nations to know him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 88

“If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me.”

LUKE 9:23

DAY 612 · WEEK 88

Luke 7:1-8:21

The centurion; the widow's son; the sinful woman; the Sower

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 7:1-8:21. A Gentile's faith, a widow's son, a sinful woman, and the parable of the sower. Notice who Jesus honors, and who he rebukes.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the Sermon on the Plain, Jesus enters Capernaum and then Nain, then dines with a Pharisee, then tells parables by the lake. Luke gathers stories that show Jesus' compassion for the outsider: a Roman soldier, a widow, a woman with a bad reputation. These are the people the religious leaders overlooked. Jesus will respond to John the Baptist's doubts by pointing to what he is doing.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I tell you, not even in Israel have I found such faith" (7:9).
2. "And when the Lord saw her, he had compassion on her and said to her, Do not weep" (7:13).
3. "The blind receive their sight, the lame walk, lepers are cleansed, and the deaf hear, the dead are raised up, the poor have good news preached to them" (7:22).
4. "But he who is forgiven little, loves little" (7:47).
5. "Your faith has saved you; go in peace" (7:50).
6. "The seed is the word of God" (8:11).
7. "And as for that in the good soil, they are those who, hearing the word, hold it fast in an honest and good heart, and bear fruit with patience" (8:15).
8. "My mother and my brothers are those who hear the word of God and do it" (8:21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

A Roman centurion sends friends to ask Jesus to heal his servant. He says he is not worthy to have Jesus come under his roof, and that Jesus need only say the word. Jesus marvels, and says he has not found such faith in Israel. A pagan soldier understood authority better than the religious insiders. Faith is believing that Jesus' word is enough.

At Nain, Jesus meets a funeral procession. A widow's only son is dead. Luke notes simply that when the Lord saw her, he had compassion. He touches the bier, speaks, and the young man sits up. Jesus gives him back to his mother. The crowd says, "God has visited his people!" That is the right conclusion.

John the Baptist, now in prison, sends disciples to ask whether Jesus is the one. Jesus does not give a direct yes. He tells them to report what they see and hear: the blind see, the lame walk, the dead are raised, the poor hear good news. These are the signs of Isaiah's promised age.

In Simon the Pharisee's house, an uninvited woman, known as a sinner, weeps on Jesus' feet, wipes them with her hair, and anoints them. Simon is scandalized. Jesus tells a story of two debtors, one forgiven a large debt and one a small debt. The one forgiven more loves more. Then he turns to the woman and says, "Your sins are forgiven." Her love was the result of forgiveness, not the cause. Simon, who thought he needed little, loved little.

The parable of the sower closes the section. The seed is the word, and the soils are hearts. Some hearts are hard, some shallow, some choked, and some good. The good soil hears, holds fast, and bears fruit with patience. Jesus' real family are not those with the right blood but those who hear and do the word of God.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 35:5-6 and 61:1 stand behind Jesus' answer to John. 1 Kings 17:17-24 is Elijah raising the widow's son, the pattern Jesus fulfills. Psalm 103:3 praises the God who forgives all your iniquity. Ephesians 2:8 says we are saved by grace through faith. Hebrews 11:6 says without faith it is impossible to please God. Romans 10:17 says faith comes from hearing. James 1:22 repeats the call to be doers of the word.

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself: which soil is closest to my heart right now? What would it take to be good soil?

Think of the woman who loved much. What has Jesus forgiven you? Let that fuel your love this week.

Be like the centurion and trust Jesus' word without needing to see how.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for his compassion for outsiders and sinners.
- Tell him how much you have been forgiven, and let love rise.
- Ask him to help you love as one who has been forgiven much.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 88

"If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me."

LUKE 9:23

DAY 613 · WEEK 88

Luke 8:22-9:50

The storm; Jairus; Peter's confession; the Transfiguration

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 80 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 8:22-9:50. A storm stilled, a girl raised, the Twelve sent out, Peter's confession, the Transfiguration. This section turns on one question: who is Jesus?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus now shows his power over nature, demons, sickness, and death. Then, in chapter 9, the question of his identity moves to the center. Herod wonders who he is, the crowds guess, Peter answers. Right after the confession, Jesus speaks plainly of his coming suffering and the cost of following him. Eight days later, three disciples see his glory on the mountain.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Master, Master, we are perishing!" (8:24).
2. "Where is your faith?" (8:25).
3. "Daughter, your faith has made you well; go in peace" (8:48).
4. "Do not fear; only believe, and she will be well" (8:50).
5. "But who do you say that I am?" Peter answered, "The Christ of God" (9:20).
6. "If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me" (9:23).
7. "This is my Son, my Chosen One; listen to him!" (9:35).
8. "For he who is least among you all is the one who is great" (9:48).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The storm on the lake shows who Jesus is. The disciples, some of them experienced fishermen, cry out that they are perishing. Jesus rebukes the wind and the waves, and there is calm. They ask, “Who then is this, that he commands even winds and water, and they obey him?” The Old Testament says only God does that (Psalm 107:29).

Then he crosses to the Gerasenes and frees a man possessed by many demons. The man, once naked and chained among the tombs, is found sitting at Jesus’ feet, clothed and in his right mind. When the people ask Jesus to leave, he tells the man to go home and declare how much God has done for him. The first missionary to the Gentiles was a former demoniac.

Jairus’s daughter and the woman with the flow of blood are woven together. The woman has been unclean and suffering for twelve years, and she touches the edge of his garment. Jesus stops, and calls her “Daughter.” A message comes that Jairus’s daughter has died. Jesus says, “Do not fear; only believe.” He takes her hand and says, “Child, arise,” and she does. Jesus is Lord over sickness and death.

The Twelve are sent out with power and authority. Herod hears and is perplexed. Jesus feeds the five thousand, and then asks the key question. The crowds say John, Elijah, or one of the prophets. Peter says, “The Christ of God.” Jesus warns them not to tell anyone yet, and speaks of suffering, rejection, death, and resurrection. Then he tells all who would follow that they must take up their cross daily. To follow the Christ is to follow the way of the cross.

Eight days later, on the mountain, Jesus is transfigured. Moses and Elijah speak with him about his “departure,” literally his exodus, which he will accomplish at Jerusalem. The voice from the cloud says, “This is my Son, my Chosen One; listen to him!” Then the disciples argue about who is greatest, and Jesus sets a child beside him. In the kingdom, greatness is humility.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 107:23-30 describes the sea stilled by the LORD. Isaiah 53 is the suffering servant behind Jesus’ words about his death. Exodus 24 and 34 recall Moses on the mountain. Deuteronomy 18:15 told Israel to listen to the coming prophet. Matthew 16:13-28 and Mark 8:27-9:1 are the parallels. Romans 6:3-5 says we are united with Christ in his death and resurrection. Galatians 2:20 says, “I have been crucified with Christ.”

STEP 6

Application

Name the storm you are in. Bring it to Jesus as the disciples did, and hear him ask, “Where is your faith?”

Answer Jesus’ own question in your own words: “Who do you say that I am?”

Take up your cross daily. What does that mean today for your habits, your time, and your pride?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Say with Peter who Jesus is.
- Tell him what storm you are facing.
- Ask him to teach you to listen to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 88

“If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me.”

LUKE 9:23

DAY 614 · WEEK 88

Luke 9:51-11:13

The Good Samaritan; Mary and Martha; teaching on prayer

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 91 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 9:51-11:13. The journey to Jerusalem begins, and with it the great central section of Luke. Notice the parable of the Good Samaritan, Mary and Martha, and the Lord's Prayer.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Luke 9:51 is the hinge of the Gospel: "When the days drew near for him to be taken up, he set his face to go to Jerusalem." From here to chapter 19, most of the material is on the road. Much of it is found only in Luke, including the Good Samaritan, Mary and Martha, and many of the parables. The journey is about discipleship, mercy, and prayer, with the cross ahead.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When the days drew near for him to be taken up, he set his face to go to Jerusalem" (9:51).
2. "Foxes have holes, and birds of the air have nests, but the Son of Man has nowhere to lay his head" (9:58).
3. "The harvest is plentiful, but the laborers are few" (10:2).
4. "You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your strength and with all your mind, and your neighbor as yourself" (10:27).
5. "But a Samaritan, as he journeyed, came to where he was, and when he saw him, he had compassion" (10:33).
6. "Mary has chosen the good portion, which will not be taken away from her" (10:42).
7. "Lord, teach us to pray" (11:1).

8 “How much more will the heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to those who ask him!” (11:13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus sets his face toward Jerusalem. A Samaritan village will not receive him, and James and John want to call down fire. Jesus rebukes them. The way of Jesus is not vengeance. Would-be followers are warned of the cost: no home, no looking back.

Seventy-two others are sent ahead, two by two, with a message of peace and the kingdom. They come back rejoicing, but Jesus says, “Do not rejoice that the spirits are subject to you, but rejoice that your names are written in heaven.” Salvation is a greater joy than power.

A lawyer asks what he must do to inherit eternal life, and Jesus asks what the Law says. The answer is to love God and neighbor. Wanting to justify himself, the lawyer asks, “Who is my neighbor?” Jesus tells of a man beaten by robbers. A priest and a Levite pass by on the other side. A Samaritan, a despised outsider, stops, binds the wounds, pays for the care. Jesus then turns the question around: not “who is my neighbor,” but “who proved to be a neighbor?” The answer is “The one who showed him mercy.” “You go, and do likewise.” Many Christians also see in the story a picture of Christ himself, the outsider who finds us half dead and pays the price. But the point of the story is mercy toward anyone in need.

At Martha and Mary’s house, Martha is busy and anxious, and Mary sits at Jesus’ feet to listen. Jesus does not scold service, but he says Mary has chosen the better thing. Hearing him comes first.

Then a disciple asks, “Lord, teach us to pray.” Jesus gives a short prayer: Father, hallowed be your name, your kingdom come, give us bread, forgive us, lead us not into temptation. He tells of the friend at midnight and urges persistence: ask, seek, knock. If earthly fathers give good gifts, how much more will the heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to those who ask. The best answer to prayer is God himself.

STEP 5

Connection

Leviticus 19:18 and Deuteronomy 6:5 are the two commands the lawyer quotes. 2 Kings 1 is Elijah calling down fire, the story James and John echo. Isaiah 50:7 says the Servant set his face like a flint. Matthew 6:9-13 gives the longer version of the Lord’s Prayer. John 4 shows Jesus with a Samaritan woman. Romans 8:15 speaks of the Spirit of adoption by whom we cry, “Abba, Father.” James 2:13 says mercy triumphs over judgment.

STEP 6

Application

Pray the Lord's Prayer slowly today, one line at a time, adding your own words to each.

Ask who the Samaritan is in your life, a person you are tempted to avoid. Show mercy to them.

Sit at Jesus' feet for ten quiet minutes before the busyness begins.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Pray the Lord's Prayer slowly in your own words.
- Ask him to teach you to sit at his feet as Mary did.
- Ask him to show you who your neighbor is.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 88

"If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me."

LUKE 9:23

DAY 615 · WEEK 88

Luke 11:14-13:21

Beelzebul; the rich fool; fear God; the narrow door

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 102 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 11:14-13:21. Conflict with the crowds and the Pharisees, warnings about hypocrisy and greed, the call to be ready, and parables of the kingdom. Read it with the question, “What do I treasure?”

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

On the road to Jerusalem the opposition grows. Some accuse Jesus of casting out demons by Satan. Others demand a sign. Jesus speaks sharply to the Pharisees and lawyers, then turns to the crowds and his disciples with teaching on fear, money, and readiness. These chapters are full of warnings, but also of tenderness: “Fear not, little flock.”

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Blessed rather are those who hear the word of God and keep it!” (11:28).
2. “Take care, and be on your guard against all covetousness, for one’s life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions” (12:15).
3. “Fool! This night your soul is required of you” (12:20).
4. “Fear not, little flock, for it is your Father’s good pleasure to give you the kingdom” (12:32).
5. “For where your treasure is, there will your heart be also” (12:34).
6. “Everyone to whom much was given, of him much will be required” (12:48).
7. “Unless you repent, you will all likewise perish” (13:3).
8. “It is like a grain of mustard seed that a man took and sowed in his garden” (13:19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

When Jesus casts out a demon, some say he does it by Beelzebul, and others ask for a sign. Jesus answers that a kingdom divided cannot stand, and that if he casts out demons by the finger of God, then the kingdom of God has come upon them. There is no neutral ground: “Whoever is not with me is against me.” The only sign will be Jonah’s: his death and resurrection. A woman in the crowd calls out a blessing on his mother, and Jesus replies that those who hear and keep the word of God are blessed rather.

At a Pharisee’s meal, Jesus points out that cleaning the outside of the cup while the inside is full of greed is foolish. Six woes follow, to the Pharisees and to the lawyers. These are not words of hatred but of heartbreak for those who keep the outward forms and miss justice and the love of God.

Then he turns to the disciples: beware the leaven of the Pharisees, which is hypocrisy. Do not fear those who kill the body. God knows each sparrow, and you are of more value than many sparrows. Whoever acknowledges Christ before others will be acknowledged before the angels of God.

A man asks Jesus to settle an inheritance dispute, and Jesus tells of the rich fool, who stored up barns of grain and planned to relax, and heard, “Fool! This night your soul is required of you.” It is folly to be rich toward self and not rich toward God. He then tells the disciples not to be anxious: the ravens and lilies are cared for. “Fear not, little flock, for it is your Father’s good pleasure to give you the kingdom.” Sell, give, and lay up treasure in heaven.

The rest of the section calls for readiness: be dressed for action, like servants waiting for the master. Much given means much required. Jesus warns that he has come to bring division, and calls for repentance when tragedies occur. The fig tree is given one more year. A woman bent over for eighteen years is healed on the Sabbath, and Jesus calls her a daughter of Abraham. Two short parables close the section: the mustard seed and the leaven. The kingdom starts small and grows beyond expectation.

STEP 5

Connection

Jonah 1 to 3 is the sign Jesus points to. Psalm 84:11 and Matthew 6:19-34 parallel his teaching on treasure and anxiety. Isaiah 5:1-7 is the background to the fig tree. Ecclesiastes 2 describes the vanity of laboring for riches. 1 Timothy 6:6-10 warns about the love of money. Hebrews 3:12-14 warns of the deceitfulness of sin. 1 Peter 5:7 says to cast all your anxieties on him.

STEP 6

Application

Look honestly at where your treasure is. What does your calendar and your bank statement say?

Name an anxiety you carry and give it to the Father who feeds the ravens.

Pray for readiness. If Jesus returned today, what would you want to have finished?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you store up for yourself and are not rich toward God.
- Thank him for giving you the kingdom.
- Ask him to loosen your grip on worry.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 88

"If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me."

LUKE 9:23

DAY 616 · WEEK 88

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Luke 9:23 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me."

LUKE 9:23

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this just after Peter's confession and his first prediction of his death. He says it to everyone: "If anyone would come after me." It is an open invitation and a hard one.

"Deny himself." This does not mean to hate yourself or to lose your identity. It means to say no to the self that sits on the throne. To follow Jesus is to stop being the center of your own life.

"Take up his cross." The cross was not a symbol of jewelry in the first century. It was an instrument of public execution, and a person who carried one was walking to his death. Jesus calls his followers to a life of surrender, willing to lose reputation, comfort, and control for his sake.

"Daily." Luke alone adds this word. The cross is not a single dramatic moment but a daily rhythm. Every morning we choose again.

“And follow me.” The road is not an empty road. We follow someone who went before us, and he did not ask us to carry anything he did not carry first. The next verse gives the promise: whoever loses his life for Jesus’ sake will save it.

When you are tempted to protect your comfort, say this verse. The way of the cross is the way of life.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you sang Psalm 116, the thanks of someone saved from death, and Psalm 117, the shortest call to the nations. In Luke 7 and 8 you saw Jesus honor a centurion’s faith, raise a widow’s son, forgive a woman who loved much, and teach about the soils of the heart. You watched him still a storm, free a demoniac, and raise Jairus’s daughter. You heard Peter confess him as the Christ of God and the Father say, “Listen to him.” On the road to Jerusalem you met the Good Samaritan, sat with Mary at Jesus’ feet, and learned to pray. You heard warnings against greed and hypocrisy and the promise to the little flock that the Father is pleased to give the kingdom.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus said Mary chose the good portion by sitting at his feet. What would it look like for you to make listening to him the first thing in your day?

In Luke 9:20, Peter confessed Jesus as the Christ of God, and then Jesus spoke of the cross. How does Jesus’ own suffering shape what it means to follow him?

The rich fool stored up treasure for himself and was not rich toward God. What is one way you can be rich toward God this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell Jesus you want to follow him and say what that costs you.

Ask him to teach you to take up your cross daily.

Thank him for going first.

DAY 617 · WEEK 89

Psalm 27

The LORD is my light and my salvation

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 27. It begins with confident trust and ends with patient waiting. Notice how fear and faith sit side by side.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 27 is a psalm of David. The first half (vv. 1-6) is bold, an army encamped around him and his heart unafraid. The second half (vv. 7-14) is a plea, almost trembling, for God to hear. Some think it is two psalms joined, but the effect is true to life: courage in the morning, anxiety in the evening, and both brought to God. It comes in the plan beside Luke's teaching on fear and trust.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD is my light and my salvation; whom shall I fear?" (v. 1).
2. "The LORD is the stronghold of my life; of whom shall I be afraid?" (v. 1).
3. "Though an army encamp against me, my heart shall not fear" (v. 3).
4. "One thing have I asked of the LORD, that will I seek after: that I may dwell in the house of the LORD all the days of my life, to gaze upon the beauty of the LORD" (v. 4).
5. "You have said, Seek my face. My heart says to you, Your face, LORD, do I seek" (v. 8).
6. "For my father and my mother have forsaken me, but the LORD will take me in" (v. 10).
7. "I believe that I shall look upon the goodness of the LORD in the land of the living!" (v. 13).
8. "Wait for the LORD; be strong, and let your heart take courage; wait for the LORD!" (v. 14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with three names for God: light, salvation, stronghold. Light shows the way and drives out darkness. Salvation delivers. A stronghold protects. With these three, David asks, “Whom shall I fear?” The questions are not worried. They expect the answer, “No one.”

Then he lists the threats: evildoers who devour, an army, war. And still: “In this I will be confident.” His confidence rests on one desire: “One thing have I asked of the LORD.” Out of all the things he could ask, he asks for God’s presence. He wants to dwell in the house of the LORD, gaze on his beauty, and inquire in his temple. In the day of trouble, God will hide him in his shelter and set him high on a rock. Then he will offer sacrifices with shouts of joy.

At verse 7 the tone shifts. “Hear, O LORD, when I cry aloud; be gracious to me and answer me!” The confident man is also a man in need. He remembers God’s invitation, “Seek my face,” and answers with the same words. He asks God not to hide his face, not to cast him off. Even if his father and mother forsake him, the LORD will take him in.

He asks to be taught God’s way and led on a level path, and he asks to be saved from false witnesses. Then verse 13 is the hinge: “I believe that I shall look upon the goodness of the LORD in the land of the living!” He does not wait for heaven to see God’s goodness. It will come here.

The last verse is an exhortation to himself and to us: wait. Be strong. Take courage. Wait. Waiting is not passive but active trust. In Luke, Jesus said, “Fear not, little flock.” David and Jesus say the same thing. The Lord is light, and there is nothing to fear in his presence.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 23 shares the theme of God’s presence in danger. Psalm 42 and 63 share the thirst for God. Isaiah 60:1 and John 8:12 speak of the light. Matthew 6:33 says to seek first the kingdom. 2 Corinthians 4:6 says God has shone in our hearts to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ. Romans 8:31 asks, “If God is for us, who can be against us?” Isaiah 40:31 promises renewed strength to those who wait on the LORD.

STEP 6

Application

Say verse 1 aloud, then name the thing you are most afraid of right now and say “Whom shall I fear?”

Write down your “one thing” from verse 4. What do you most want from God?

Choose something to wait on in prayer, and wait with courage.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what you fear, and say, “The LORD is my light and my salvation.”

Ask him for the one thing: to dwell with him and see his beauty.

Tell him you wait for him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 89

“Just so, I tell you, there will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance.”

LUKE 15:7

DAY 618 · WEEK 89

Psalm 28

Hear the voice of my pleas for mercy

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 28. It begins with a desperate cry and ends with a shout of praise. Notice what changes between verse 5 and verse 6.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 28 is a psalm of David. He is surrounded by wicked people and fears being swept away with them. He cries to the LORD, his rock, and asks for justice. Halfway through there is a change: he hears the answer, and the psalm ends in praise and a prayer for God's people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "To you, O LORD, I call; my rock, be not deaf to me" (v. 1).
2. "Hear the voice of my pleas for mercy, as I cry to you for help" (v. 2).
3. "Do not drag me off with the wicked" (v. 3).
4. "Because they do not regard the works of the LORD, or the work of his hands, he will tear them down and build them up no more" (v. 5).
5. "Blessed be the LORD! For he has heard the voice of my pleas for mercy" (v. 6).
6. "The LORD is my strength and my shield; in him my heart trusts, and I am helped" (v. 7).
7. "The LORD is the strength of his people; he is the saving refuge of his anointed" (v. 8).
8. "Oh, save your people and bless your heritage! Be their shepherd and carry them forever" (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David's fear is silence. "If you are deaf to me, I become like those who go down to the pit." He cannot bear the thought that God might not answer. He lifts his hands toward the holy sanctuary, and asks God not to treat him as he treats the wicked, whose speech is smooth but whose hearts are full of evil.

He prays for justice in verse 4, asking that they receive what their deeds deserve. This is not personal revenge. It is the cry for a righteous God to act against evil. The reason is verse 5: they do not regard the works of the LORD. They ignore him and act as though no one will answer.

Then, without a transition, the mood changes. "Blessed be the LORD! For he has heard the voice of my pleas for mercy." Between verses 5 and 6, something has happened. Perhaps a priest spoke a word of assurance, or perhaps David simply felt the burden lift. Whatever it was, he now says, "The LORD is my strength and my shield; in him my heart trusts, and I am helped; my heart exults, and with my song I give thanks to him."

The final verses widen the circle. The LORD is not just his strength but "the strength of his people." He is the saving refuge of his anointed. And David asks for the whole flock: "Save your people and bless your heritage. Be their shepherd and carry them forever." The same shepherd who walked with David is asked to carry all his people.

Jesus is the final Shepherd and the final Anointed. He cried out to his Father in distress and was heard. And now he carries his flock.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 23 and Ezekiel 34 describe the LORD as shepherd. Psalm 18:2 uses the same strength and shield language. Psalm 22:24 says he has not hidden his face but has heard when he cried to him. John 10:11-16 shows Jesus as the Good Shepherd. Hebrews 5:7 says Jesus offered up prayers with loud cries and tears, and was heard. 1 Peter 5:4 speaks of the Chief Shepherd.

STEP 6

Application

Take a burden to the LORD today, and keep praying until you can, like David, bless him.

Pray verse 9 for your church: save your people, bless them, shepherd them, and carry them.

Thank God for a time he heard you when you felt unheard.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to hear your pleas for mercy.
- Thank him that he is your strength and shield.
- Bless him for hearing you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 89

"Just so, I tell you, there will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance."

LUKE 15:7

DAY 619 · WEEK 89

Psalm 31:1-18

Into your hands I commit my spirit

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 31:1-18. This is a psalm of trust in deep distress. Verse 5 is the one Jesus prayed on the cross, and you will meet it again in Luke 23.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 31 is a psalm of David written when he was in danger, grieving, and slandered. It moves back and forth between trust and complaint, a mark of honest prayer. The first eighteen verses cover the prayer for refuge, the description of suffering, and the declaration, "My times are in your hand." The rest of the psalm (vv. 19 to 24) comes in a few days.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In you, O LORD, do I take refuge; let me never be put to shame; in your righteousness deliver me!" (v. 1).
2. "Be to me a rock of refuge, a strong fortress to save me!" (v. 2).
3. "For you are my rock and my fortress" (v. 3).
4. "Into your hand I commit my spirit; you have redeemed me, O LORD, faithful God" (v. 5).
5. "Be gracious to me, O LORD, for I am in distress" (v. 9).
6. "For my life is spent with sorrow, and my years with sighing" (v. 10).
7. "But I trust in you, O LORD; I say, You are my God" (v. 14).
8. "My times are in your hand" (v. 15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm starts with a refuge. David has run to the LORD, and he asks to be delivered. He uses the image of a rock and a fortress, and asks the LORD to lead and guide him "for your name's sake." Whatever happens, God's own honor is tied to his people.

Verse 5 is the center: "Into your hand I commit my spirit; you have redeemed me, O LORD, faithful God." This was a prayer a pious Jew might say at bedtime. It means, "I place my life in your keeping." Jesus will pray it on the cross, with one change: he begins with "Father." The prayer David prayed in danger is the prayer Jesus prayed in death, and it has been the prayer of many Christians in their last moments.

Then David describes his suffering. He is in distress. His eye, soul, and body waste away with grief. His strength fails because of his iniquity, and his bones waste away. He has become a reproach to his adversaries and an object of dread to his neighbors. People who see him flee from him. He is forgotten like one who is dead, a broken vessel. He hears the whispering of many, terror on every side, as they scheme to take his life.

And yet: "But I trust in you, O LORD; I say, You are my God." The word "but" turns the psalm. In the middle of terror he declares, "My times are in your hand." All of life's seasons, the good and the bad, are in God's hand. No enemy can reach beyond it. So he asks God to make his face shine on him and to save him in his steadfast love.

This is the heart of faith. It does not deny the pain, and it does not say the pain is small. It says that the pain is held by a hand that is good.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 23:46 has Jesus praying verse 5 on the cross. Acts 7:59 has Stephen praying a similar prayer at his death. Jonah 2:8 and Psalm 71:1-3 parallel the refuge language. Psalm 22 is also a psalm of suffering and trust. Romans 8:28 says God works all things together for good. 1 Peter 4:19 says to entrust your souls to a faithful Creator. 1 Peter 5:7 says to cast all your anxieties on him.

STEP 6

Application

Pray verse 5 tonight before you sleep, and let it become a habit.

Write "My times are in your hand" on a card and place it where you will see it.

Name a season of your life that feels out of control and entrust it to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Commit your spirit into God's hand, as Jesus did.
- Tell him what you need as your refuge.
- Thank him for redeeming you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 89

"Just so, I tell you, there will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance."

LUKE 15:7

DAY 620 · WEEK 89

Luke 13:22-15:32

The narrow door; the great banquet; the lost sheep, coin, son

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 81 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 13:22-15:32. The narrow door, a banquet where the guests make excuses, the cost of discipleship, and three parables about the lost: a sheep, a coin, and a son. Chapter 15 is among the most loved in the Bible.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus is still on the way to Jerusalem. Someone asks whether only a few will be saved, and Jesus replies with a warning. Then he dines with a Pharisee on the Sabbath and tells about banquets. Tax collectors and sinners draw near to hear him, and the Pharisees grumble. In response, Jesus tells three parables of lost things, and the third becomes the best known of all his stories.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Strive to enter through the narrow door” (13:24).
2. “O Jerusalem, Jerusalem, the city that kills the prophets… How often would I have gathered your children together as a hen gathers her brood under her wings, and you were not willing!” (13:34).
3. “For everyone who exalts himself will be humbled, and he who humbles himself will be exalted” (14:11).
4. “Go out to the highways and hedges and compel people to come in, that my house may be filled” (14:23).
5. “Whoever does not bear his own cross and come after me cannot be my disciple” (14:27).

6. “There will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance” (15:7).

7. “But while he was still a long way off, his father saw him and felt compassion, and ran and embraced him and kissed him” (15:20).

8. “For this your brother was dead, and is alive; he was lost, and is found” (15:32).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Someone asks if only a few will be saved. Jesus does not answer with a number but with a command: strive to enter the narrow door. Many will seek to enter and not be able. The door will be shut, and those outside will say, “We ate and drank in your presence.” Being near Jesus is not the same as knowing him. Yet people will come from east, west, north, and south to sit at table in the kingdom, and “some who are last will be first.” Jesus mourns over Jerusalem like a mother hen. “You were not willing.”

At a Pharisee’s table, Jesus heals a man with dropsy, and teaches that the humble will be exalted. He tells the host to invite the poor, the crippled, the lame, and the blind, who cannot repay. Then he tells of a great banquet where invited guests make excuses. The master sends his servants to the poor, then to the highways and hedges. “That my house may be filled.” The kingdom is a feast, and the grace of the host reaches the outcast. Jesus then warns the crowds about the cost of following him. One must count the cost, like a builder or a king. No one can be his disciple without giving up everything.

The three parables of chapter 15 answer the grumbling Pharisees. A shepherd leaves ninety-nine to find one lost sheep, carries it home on his shoulders, and calls friends to rejoice. A woman sweeps the house for one lost coin, and rejoices when it is found. In each, the lost is sought and found, and heaven rejoices.

The third story is of a father and two sons. The younger son demands his inheritance, wastes it, and ends up feeding pigs. “He came to himself.” He plans a speech and heads home. “While he was still a long way off, his father saw him,” ran, embraced him, and kissed him. He interrupts the speech, calls for the best robe, a ring, sandals, and a feast. This is how God receives a returning sinner.

But there is an older brother, who stays outside, angry. He has been dutiful, yet he does not share his father’s joy. The father goes out to him, too: “All that is mine is yours. It was fitting to celebrate.” The story ends without telling us whether he goes in. Jesus leaves the Pharisees with the question. Will they join the feast, or stay outside?

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 55:6-7 invites the wicked to return to the LORD, who will abundantly pardon. Ezekiel 34:11-16 has God as the seeking shepherd. Psalm 103:8-13 says the LORD has compassion as a father has compassion on his children. Hosea 11 shows God's tender love for a wandering son. Matthew 7:13-14 parallels the narrow gate. Romans 5:8 says God shows his love in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us. Ephesians 2:13 says we who were far off have been brought near.

STEP 6

Application

Imagine yourself in the story as the younger son, then as the older. Which is harder to see in yourself?

Is there someone you have written off as lost? Pray for them by name.

Celebrate when someone repents or comes to faith. Heaven does.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for running to meet you while you were far off.
- Tell him where you have been the older brother.
- Rejoice with him over those who come home.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 89

"Just so, I tell you, there will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance."

LUKE 15:7

DAY 621 · WEEK 89

Luke 16:1-17:37

The rich man and Lazarus; faith; the coming kingdom

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 68 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 16:1-17:37. A shrewd manager, the rich man and Lazarus, warnings about stumbling, forgiveness, faith, ten lepers, and the coming of the kingdom. These are hard sayings. Read slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

On the road to Jerusalem, Jesus continues to teach the disciples while the Pharisees, who love money, listen and scoff. His teaching in these chapters keeps coming back to money, faithfulness, and readiness for the kingdom. Luke 16 is the most pointed teaching on wealth in the Gospels.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “One who is faithful in a very little is also faithful in much” (16:10).
2. “You cannot serve God and money” (16:13).
3. “Son, remember that you in your lifetime received your good things, and Lazarus in like manner bad things” (16:25).
4. “If they do not hear Moses and the Prophets, neither will they be convinced if someone should rise from the dead” (16:31).
5. “Increase our faith!” (17:5).
6. “If you had faith like a grain of mustard seed” (17:6).
7. “Were not ten cleansed? Where are the nine?” (17:17).
8. “For behold, the kingdom of God is in the midst of you” (17:21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The parable of the shrewd manager is puzzling. A manager, about to be fired, reduces the debts of his master's debtors to make friends. The master commends his shrewdness. Jesus does not praise dishonesty. The point is that the people of this age plan ahead for their future, so the children of light should use worldly wealth with an eye to eternity. "Make friends for yourselves by means of unrighteous wealth." Money is a tool, not a master: "You cannot serve God and money." The Pharisees sneer, and Jesus tells them that what is exalted among men is an abomination in the sight of God.

Then comes the rich man and Lazarus. A rich man dresses in purple and feasts daily, while a beggar named Lazarus lies at his gate covered with sores. Both die. Lazarus is carried by angels to Abraham's side, and the rich man is in torment. This is the only parable in which a character has a name, and he is the poor one. The rich man asks Abraham to send Lazarus to warn his brothers. Abraham answers, "They have Moses and the Prophets." If they do not listen to Scripture, they will not be convinced even by one who rises from the dead. The story is a warning about hardened hearts, and an irony: someone did rise from the dead, and many did not believe.

Chapter 17 begins with a warning about causing little ones to stumble, and a call to forgive repeatedly. The apostles say, "Increase our faith!" Jesus replies that faith the size of a mustard seed can do surprising things. It is not the quantity but the object that matters. Then he tells them that servants who have done all that was commanded say, "We are unworthy servants."

Ten lepers are healed, and only one returns to give thanks, a Samaritan. Jesus says, "Your faith has made you well." Then the Pharisees ask when the kingdom will come, and Jesus replies, "The kingdom of God is in the midst of you." The King is standing among them. He then speaks of the days of the Son of Man, which will come suddenly like lightning, and warns, "Remember Lot's wife."

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 15:7-11 commands generosity toward the poor. Proverbs 14:31 says whoever oppresses the poor shows contempt for his Maker. Isaiah 8:19-20 sends people to the law and the testimony. Matthew 6:24 has the same saying about two masters. Luke 24:25-27 returns to the importance of Moses and the Prophets. 1 Timothy 6:17-19 gives instructions to the rich. 2 Kings 5 recounts the healing of Naaman, the leper who was a foreigner. 1 Thessalonians 5:18 says to give thanks in all circumstances.

STEP 6

Application

Look at your own giving and spending. Are you using money as a tool for eternity?

Be the one leper who returns. Write a thank you note to God or to someone who has helped you.

Read your Bible faithfully. Moses and the Prophets still speak.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you are tempted to serve besides him, such as money.
- Ask him to open your eyes to the “Lazarus” at your gate.
- Ask him to teach you to be faithful in little.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 89

“Just so, I tell you, there will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance.”

LUKE 15:7

DAY 622 · WEEK 89

Luke 18:1-19:27

The widow and judge; the Pharisee and the tax collector; Zacchaeus

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 70 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 18:1-19:27. Two parables about prayer, children brought to Jesus, a rich ruler, a blind man healed, and Zacchaeus. Chapter 19:10 is the key verse of the whole Gospel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus is near the end of his journey. He is about to enter Jericho and then go up to Jerusalem. These chapters hold several of Luke's best known scenes: the Pharisee and the tax collector, Zacchaeus, and the parable of the minas. They show who receives the kingdom: the humble, the childlike, the despised, and the seeking.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "He told them a parable to the effect that they ought always to pray and not lose heart" (18:1).
2. "And will not God give justice to his elect, who cry to him day and night?" (18:7).
3. "God, be merciful to me, a sinner!" (18:13).
4. "For everyone who exalts himself will be humbled, but the one who humbles himself will be exalted" (18:14).
5. "Let the children come to me, and do not hinder them, for to such belongs the kingdom of God" (18:16).
6. "What is impossible with men is possible with God" (18:27).
7. "Zacchaeus, hurry and come down, for I must stay at your house today" (19:5).
8. "For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost" (19:10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The widow and the unjust judge teach persistence. A widow keeps coming to a judge who neither fears God nor respects people, and finally he gives her justice because she wears him out. If even an unjust judge responds, how much more will God, who is just and loving, answer his chosen ones? The lesson is to pray always and not lose heart.

The Pharisee and the tax collector teach humility. The Pharisee stands and thanks God that he is not like other men. The tax collector stands far off, beats his chest, and says, "God, be merciful to me, a sinner!" Jesus says this man went down to his house justified. Justification comes through humble faith in God's mercy, not through the record of our good deeds.

Parents bring infants to Jesus, and the disciples try to stop them. Jesus welcomes them and says the kingdom belongs to such as these, and that whoever does not receive it like a child will not enter it. Then a rich ruler asks what he must do to inherit eternal life. Jesus points him to the commandments, and then says to sell everything and follow him. The man goes away sad, for he is very rich. Jesus says it is hard for the rich to enter the kingdom. The bystanders ask, "Who then can be saved?" and Jesus answers, "What is impossible with men is possible with God." Salvation is a miracle.

For the third time, Jesus speaks of his death in Jerusalem. The disciples do not understand. Outside Jericho, a blind beggar cries, "Jesus, Son of David, have mercy on me!" The crowd tells him to be quiet, but he cries out louder. Jesus heals him, and he follows, glorifying God.

In Jericho, Zacchaeus, a chief tax collector and wealthy, climbs a sycamore tree to see Jesus. Jesus calls him by name and invites himself to his house. The crowd grumbles. Zacchaeus repents, gives half his goods to the poor, and repays fourfold anyone he cheated. Jesus says, "Today salvation has come to this house." Then verse 10 summarizes his whole mission: "For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost." The parable of the minas follows, to correct the idea that the kingdom will appear at once. The King is going away, and his servants are to be faithful until he returns.

STEP 5

Connection

Habakkuk 2:4 says the righteous shall live by his faith. Psalm 51:1-4 is the prayer of a broken sinner. Psalm 34:18 says the LORD is near to the brokenhearted. Isaiah 66:2 says God looks to the humble and contrite. Ezekiel 34:16 promises that God will seek the lost. Romans 3:21-26 explains justification by faith. Luke 15 gave three parables of the lost. 1 Timothy 1:15 says Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners.

STEP 6

Application

Pray the tax collector's prayer slowly, ten times: "God, be merciful to me, a sinner."

Keep praying for the thing you have prayed about for the longest time. Do not lose heart.

Ask who the Zacchaeus is in your life, someone others have written off. Reach out to them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to teach you to pray always and not lose heart.
- Pray, "God, be merciful to me, a sinner," and mean it.
- Thank Jesus for receiving sinners like Zacchaeus.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 89

"Just so, I tell you, there will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance."

LUKE 15:7

DAY 623 · WEEK 89

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Luke 15:7 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Just so, I tell you, there will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance."

LUKE 15:7

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this at the end of the parable of the lost sheep, to Pharisees who complained that he welcomed sinners and ate with them. It is his answer to their grumbling and a window into the heart of heaven.

"Just so." The shepherd's joy over the found sheep is a picture of heaven's joy. Jesus is not describing an anxious God who tolerates repentant sinners. He is describing a God who celebrates.

"More joy in heaven." Heaven is not a quiet place. It rejoices. When a single person turns from sin and trusts in God, the angels rejoice and the Father himself is glad. Your repentance was a reason for celebration in heaven.

“One sinner who repents.” One, not a crowd. Each person matters to God. The shepherd left ninety-nine to seek one. Repentance here means a change of mind and direction, turning from self and sin to God.

“Ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance.” Jesus says this with irony, for the Pharisees thought they were righteous. In truth, everyone needs to repent. The only people who miss the party are those who think they do not need it.

If you have ever felt that God is disappointed in you, say this verse. When you come home, he runs to meet you.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you prayed Psalm 27 and its bold trust, “Whom shall I fear?”, and Psalm 28, which moves from a cry to praise. Psalm 31:1-18 gave you the prayer “Into your hand I commit my spirit,” and “My times are in your hand.” In Luke 13 to 19 you heard Jesus warn about the narrow door and tell the stories of the lost sheep, the lost coin, and the lost son, in which a father runs to meet a returning child. You listened to his hard words about money, the rich man and Lazarus, the ten lepers, and the coming of the kingdom. You saw a widow persist in prayer, a tax collector go home justified, a blind man receive his sight, and Zacchaeus climb down from a tree. You read the verse that sums up the Gospel: “The Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost.”

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

In the parable of the lost son, the father runs to meet the returning child. What does this tell you about how God receives you when you come back to him?

Jesus said he came to seek and to save the lost (19:10). How does his seeking of Zacchaeus, and of you, show who Jesus is?

The tax collector prayed, “God, be merciful to me, a sinner.” Where do you need to stop justifying yourself and simply ask for mercy?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that heaven rejoices over one sinner who repents.

Thank him for seeking you and bringing you home.

Ask him to keep you from the elder brother’s spirit.

DAY 624 · WEEK 90

Luke 19:28-21:38

The Entry; controversies; the widow's offering; signs of the end

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 116 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 19:28-21:38. The King rides into Jerusalem, weeps over the city, cleanses the temple, and teaches there while the leaders try to trap him. It ends with his words about the end of the age. Read it as the week before the cross.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The long journey is over. Jesus comes to Jerusalem at the time of Passover. For the next few days he teaches in the temple, answering questions from priests, scribes, Pharisees, Sadducees, and the Herodians. Each group tries to catch him in his words, and each is silenced. Luke records the events in an orderly way, and the shadow of the cross lies over every scene.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Blessed is the King who comes in the name of the Lord! Peace in heaven and glory in the highest!" (19:38).
2. "Would that you, even you, had known on this day the things that make for peace!" (19:42).
3. "It is written, And my house shall be a house of prayer, but you have made it a den of robbers" (19:46).
4. "The stone that the builders rejected has become the cornerstone" (20:17).
5. "Then render to Caesar the things that are Caesar's, and to God the things that are God's" (20:25).
6. "Now he is not God of the dead but of the living, for all live to him" (20:38).

7. “Truly, I tell you, this poor widow has put in more than all of them” (21:3).

8. “Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away” (21:33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus sends two disciples for a colt that no one has ever ridden. As he rides toward the city, the crowd of disciples spreads cloaks on the road and cries out, “Blessed is the King who comes in the name of the Lord!” Zechariah 9:9 is being fulfilled. When the Pharisees ask him to rebuke them, he says that if they were silent, the very stones would cry out.

But as he draws near and sees the city, he weeps. He knows that Jerusalem does not recognize the time of her visitation, and he foretells its destruction, which came in AD 70. The King who enters in triumph weeps for those who reject him.

In the temple he drives out those who sell, saying the house is meant to be a house of prayer. Then he teaches daily, and the chief priests and scribes seek to destroy him but cannot find a way, because all the people hang on his words.

They challenge his authority, and he answers with a question about John’s baptism. They will not answer, so neither will he. Then he tells the parable of the wicked tenants. A man plants a vineyard and sends servants, who are beaten, and finally his beloved son, whom they kill. This is the story of Israel’s leaders and of Jesus himself. He quotes Psalm 118: the rejected stone becomes the cornerstone.

Then come the traps. Is it lawful to pay taxes to Caesar? “Render to Caesar the things that are Caesar’s, and to God the things that are God’s.” The Sadducees, who deny the resurrection, ask about the woman married to seven brothers. Jesus answers that those who rise are like angels and that God is the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, “not God of the dead but of the living.” Then Jesus asks his own question: how can the Christ be David’s son, when David calls him Lord (Psalm 110)? Because he is both. Jesus warns against the scribes who devour widows’ houses, and then points out a poor widow who put in two small coins. She gave all she had.

The last chapter is the Olivet discourse, speaking of the destruction of the temple, persecution, signs in the sun, moon, and stars, and the coming of the Son of Man with power and great glory. Jesus’ call is: “Straighten up and raise your heads, because your redemption is drawing near.” Stay awake, and pray that you may have strength to stand before the Son of Man. Interpreters differ on how to divide what refers to AD 70 and what refers to the end of the age, but the pastoral aim is clear: be watchful, and do not be afraid.

STEP 5

Connection

Zechariah 9:9 is the prophecy of the humble king on a donkey. Psalm 118:22-26 is the background to the crowd's shout and the cornerstone. Isaiah 5:1-7 is the vineyard song behind the tenants. Psalm 110:1 is the verse Jesus asks about. Jeremiah 7:11 is the "den of robbers." Daniel 7:13-14 describes the Son of Man coming with the clouds. Exodus 3:6 is the verse Jesus cites for the resurrection. Romans 13:1-7 teaches about the state.

STEP 6

Application

Welcome Jesus as King today. Is there an area of your life where you would rather he not enter?

Give something to God out of what you need, not just out of your surplus, like the widow.

Practice watchfulness. Pray for strength for whatever is ahead.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Welcome Jesus as King, and tell him what you want to lay at his feet.
- Ask him to give you tears for what he weeps over.
- Ask him to teach you to give, like the widow, all you have.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 90

"This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me."

LUKE 22:19

DAY 625 · WEEK 90

Psalm 31:19-24

Oh, how abundant is your goodness

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 31:19-24. This is the second half of the psalm you read on Day 619. After the trouble, the singer turns to thanks. Read it with the verses 1 to 18 fresh in your mind.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The first half of Psalm 31 was a prayer in the middle of distress. These closing verses look back from the other side. David has been heard, and he reflects on the goodness of God that is stored up for those who trust him. He ends by calling all God's people to love him and take courage.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh, how abundant is your goodness" (v. 19).
2. "stored up for those who fear you" (v. 19).
3. "In the cover of your presence you hide them from the plots of men" (v. 20).
4. "he has wondrously shown his steadfast love to me when I was in a besieged city" (v. 21).
5. "I had said in my alarm, I am cut off from your sight" (v. 22).
6. "you heard the voice of my pleas for mercy" (v. 22).
7. "Love the LORD, all you his saints!" (v. 23).
8. "Be strong, and let your heart take courage, all who wait for the LORD!" (v. 24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Verse 19 is an exclamation: “Oh, how abundant is your goodness!” David is overwhelmed. The goodness of God is not scarce, and it is stored up, like treasure in a storehouse, for those who fear him and take refuge in him. It is given “in the sight of the children of mankind,” so that others can see.

Verse 20 describes how it is delivered. God hides his people “in the cover of your presence” from the plots of men and “in your shelter from the strife of tongues.” David had been slandered (see verse 13), and he knows that God’s nearness is the safest place.

In verse 21, he blesses the LORD for showing steadfast love in a “besieged city.” He had felt trapped, surrounded, and helpless. Then he admits, “I had said in my alarm, I am cut off from your sight.” This is the honest confession of a believer who felt abandoned. But he was not. “You heard the voice of my pleas for mercy when I cried to you for help.” What he felt in alarm was not the truth. God had been listening all along.

Then David turns outward. “Love the LORD, all you his saints!” He has learned something he wants others to know. The LORD preserves the faithful, and abundantly repays the proud. And the last words are an encouragement: “Be strong, and let your heart take courage, all who wait for the LORD.”

Read this beside Luke 19 to 21. Jesus entered a besieged city in the week of his death. He felt the plots of men. Yet he was not cut off, and the Father vindicated him. And because of the cross, the goodness stored up for those who take refuge in God is ours.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 27:13-14 ends with almost the same call to wait and take courage. Psalm 34:8-10 says to taste and see that the LORD is good. Isaiah 64:4 and 1 Corinthians 2:9 speak of what God has prepared for those who wait for him. Romans 8:35-39 says nothing can separate us from the love of God. Ephesians 1:3 says he has blessed us with every spiritual blessing. Jonah 2:4 echoes the feeling of being cast out from his sight.

STEP 6

Application

Make a list of the goodness God has stored up and given you. Thank him for each one.

Remember a time you felt cut off from God and he was close. Write it down.

Tell a friend, as David does: love the LORD.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for goodness he has stored up for those who fear him.

Thank him for hiding you in the cover of his presence.

Ask him to make you strong and take heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 90

"This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me."

LUKE 22:19

DAY 626 · WEEK 90

Psalm 41

Blessed is the one who considers the poor

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 41. It closes the first book of the Psalter. Notice verse 9, which Jesus applies to Judas in John 13, and the blessing for those who care for the poor at the beginning.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 41 is a psalm of David written in illness, when enemies gloated and a close friend turned against him. It begins with a beatitude for the one who considers the poor, and it ends with a doxology that closes the first of the five books of the Psalms. It comes in the plan at the point in Luke where the shadow of betrayal falls.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Blessed is the one who considers the poor! In the day of trouble the LORD delivers him” (v. 1).
2. “The LORD sustains him on his sickbed; in his illness you restore him to full health” (v. 3).
3. “As for me, I said, O LORD, be gracious to me; heal me, for I have sinned against you!” (v. 4).
4. “My enemies say of me in malice: When will he die, and his name perish?” (v. 5).
5. “Even my close friend in whom I trusted, who ate my bread, has lifted his heel against me” (v. 9).
6. “By this I know that you delight in me: my enemy will not shout in triumph over me” (v. 11).

7. “But you have upheld me because of my integrity, and set me in your presence forever” (v. 12).

8. “Blessed be the LORD, the God of Israel, from everlasting to everlasting! Amen and Amen” (v. 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a blessing on those who consider the poor. This means paying attention, thinking about, and caring for the weak. The reward is that the LORD delivers them in the day of trouble, protects them, keeps them alive, and sustains them on a sickbed.

Then David turns to his own distress. He is sick, and he prays, “O LORD, be gracious to me; heal me, for I have sinned against you!” He does not claim innocence. He asks for mercy, trusting that God’s grace is greater than his guilt.

His enemies wait for him to die. Visitors come with empty words, and then go out to spread slander. “They imagine the worst for me.” Then comes the sharpest pain: “Even my close friend in whom I trusted, who ate my bread, has lifted his heel against me.” Betrayal by someone who shared your table is a particular kind of grief.

Jesus quotes this verse at the Last Supper (John 13:18) about Judas. David’s betrayal by his friend, probably Ahithophel, is a pattern of the greater betrayal of the Son of David. In Luke 22, Jesus eats the Passover with his betrayer at the table.

David asks to be raised up, so that he may repay them. But he trusts that God delights in him because the enemy has not triumphed. “You have upheld me because of my integrity, and set me in your presence forever.” David’s integrity is not sinlessness but the sincerity of one who has confessed and been forgiven. The end of the psalm is the doxology that closes Book I: “Blessed be the LORD, the God of Israel, from everlasting to everlasting! Amen and Amen.”

For Christians, the one who truly considered the poor, who bore betrayal, and who was upheld and raised up forever, is Jesus.

STEP 5

Connection

John 13:18 quotes verse 9. 2 Samuel 15 to 17 tells of Ahithophel’s betrayal of David. Matthew 26:14-16 and Luke 22:3-6 describe Judas’s betrayal. Proverbs 14:21 and 19:17 speak of kindness to the poor. Psalm 72:12-14 says the king delivers the needy. 2 Corinthians 8:9 says Christ became poor for our sake. Matthew 25:31-46 describes the judgment in terms of care for the least.

STEP 6

Application

Consider the poor this week: give, visit, or serve someone in need.

If you have been betrayed, bring it to the LORD in prayer. Forgive as he leads you.

Pray David's prayer in verse 4 honestly, naming your sins and asking for grace.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to be gracious and heal you, and tell him your sin.
- Ask him to teach you to consider the poor.
- Thank Jesus, who knows the pain of betrayal.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 90

"This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me."

LUKE 22:19

DAY 627 · WEEK 90

Psalm 55:1-23

My companion stretched out his hand against me

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Psalm · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 55:1-23. David's closest friend betrays him, and he longs to fly away. Notice the turn in verse 22, and read it against the betrayal in Luke 22.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 55 is a psalm of David, probably from the time of Absalom's rebellion, when his trusted advisor Ahithophel joined the conspiracy. David is in anguish. The city is full of violence, and the one who hurt him the most was a friend. It is one of the most honest psalms about betrayal, and it ends with one of the most quoted verses in the Psalter.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Give ear to my prayer, O God, and hide not yourself from my plea for mercy!" (v. 1).
2. "My heart is in anguish within me; the terrors of death have fallen upon me" (v. 4).
3. "Oh, that I had wings like a dove! I would fly away and be at rest" (v. 6).
4. "But it is you, a man, my equal, my companion, my familiar friend" (v. 13).
5. "We used to take sweet counsel together; within God's house we walked in the throng" (v. 14).
6. "His speech was smooth as butter, yet war was in his heart" (v. 21).
7. "Cast your burden on the LORD, and he will sustain you; he will never permit the righteous to be moved" (v. 22).
8. "But I will trust in you" (v. 23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David begins with a plea: “Give ear to my prayer.” He is restless, he moans, his heart is in anguish. Fear and trembling overwhelm him, and horror covers him. In the middle of that, he wishes he could escape: “Oh, that I had wings like a dove! I would fly away and be at rest.” Everyone has felt this. We want to flee the pain, find a quiet place, and wait out the storm.

The city is full of violence and strife, and iniquity and trouble are within it. But what hurts most is not the enemy outside. “It is not an enemy who taunts me; then I could bear it… But it is you, a man, my equal, my companion, my familiar friend.” They had walked together to the house of God. The betrayer had broken covenant. His speech was smooth as butter, “yet war was in his heart.”

Notice what David does. He does not hide his rage. He asks God to confuse the tongues of the wicked and to bring them down. But he also does something more: he calls on God, evening, morning, and noon, and God hears.

And then, the center of the psalm: “Cast your burden on the LORD, and he will sustain you; he will never permit the righteous to be moved.” David speaks to himself and to us. A burden you cannot carry can be put on someone who can. The word here is gift or lot, whatever has been given to you. Give it to the LORD, and he will hold you up. The final line is a short declaration: “But I will trust in you.”

Peter later quotes this verse: “Casting all your anxieties on him, because he cares for you.” And Jesus, betrayed in a garden by a friend with a kiss, lived this psalm. He cast his burden on the Father. In Gethsemane he prayed, “Not my will, but yours,” and he was sustained. His betrayal means that when we are betrayed, we have a High Priest who understands.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Samuel 15:12 and 17:23 tell of Ahithophel’s betrayal and death. Psalm 41:9 uses the same betrayal imagery. Matthew 26:47-50 shows Judas’s kiss. Luke 22:48 is Jesus’ word to Judas. 1 Peter 5:7 quotes verse 22. Philippians 4:6-7 invites us to bring everything to God in prayer. Hebrews 4:15 says Jesus can sympathize with our weaknesses. Matthew 11:28 invites the weary to come to him.

STEP 6

Application

Name your burden aloud and give it to the LORD. Do it again when it returns.

If you are tempted to run, ask where you can find rest, then go to him in prayer.

Pray for the one who hurt you. Entrust the justice to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God the anguish of your heart.
- Cast your burden on him and tell him what it is.
- Thank him that he sustains you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 90

"This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me."

LUKE 22:19

DAY 628 · WEEK 90

Luke 22:1-46

The Last Supper; teaching on greatness; Gethsemane

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 46 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 22:1-46. The plot, the betrayal bargain, the Last Supper, the argument about greatness, Peter's warning, and Gethsemane. Read slowly, and let the Supper words settle.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is the week of Passover. The religious leaders are looking for a way to put Jesus to death without upsetting the people. Satan enters Judas. In an upper room, Jesus eats the Passover with his disciples and gives the meal a new meaning. Then he leads them to the Mount of Olives to pray, as was his custom. Luke's account is among the most intimate in the Gospels.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Then Satan entered into Judas called Iscariot, who was of the number of the twelve" (22:3).
2. "I have earnestly desired to eat this Passover with you before I suffer" (22:15).
3. "This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me" (22:19).
4. "This cup that is poured out for you is the new covenant in my blood" (22:20).
5. "But not so with you. Rather, let the greatest among you become as the youngest, and the leader as one who serves" (22:26).
6. "But I have prayed for you that your faith may not fail. And when you have turned again, strengthen your brothers" (22:32).
7. "Father, if you are willing, remove this cup from me. Nevertheless, not my will, but yours, be done" (22:42).

8 “Why are you sleeping? Rise and pray that you may not enter into temptation” (22:46).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Luke moves quickly. The leaders are afraid of the people, and Satan enters Judas, who agrees to betray Jesus for money. Meanwhile Jesus sends Peter and John to prepare the Passover meal.

At the table, Jesus says, “I have earnestly desired to eat this Passover with you before I suffer.” He takes bread and says, “This is my body, given for you,” and after supper takes the cup and says, “This cup that is poured out for you is the new covenant in my blood.” This is the heart of the chapter. The Passover remembered the lamb whose blood spared Israel in Egypt. Now Jesus says that his body and blood will be given for his people. He is the Lamb, and the new covenant promised in Jeremiah 31 is being inaugurated by his death. Christians have disagreed about exactly how Christ is present in the Supper, but all agree that he commanded the church to keep it, and that it proclaims his death until he comes.

At the table, Jesus names his betrayer, and the disciples argue about which of them is the greatest. It is one of the saddest scenes in the Gospels. Jesus answers with a reversal: the kings of the Gentiles lord it over them, but “not so with you.” The greatest must be as the youngest, and the leader as one who serves. “I am among you as the one who serves.” Then he promises that they will sit on thrones, a covenant of kingdom from his Father.

He turns to Peter: “Satan demanded to have you, that he might sift you like wheat, but I have prayed for you that your faith may not fail.” Notice that Jesus does not say he will keep Peter from falling. He says he has prayed that his faith will not fail, and that Peter will turn again and strengthen his brothers. Jesus foretells Peter’s denial, and Peter swears he will never deny him.

On the Mount of Olives, Jesus withdraws a stone’s throw and prays: “Father, if you are willing, remove this cup from me. Nevertheless, not my will, but yours, be done.” An angel strengthens him. Then in agony he prays more earnestly. (Some early manuscripts omit verses 43 and 44, but the scene they describe fits the whole.) He finds the disciples sleeping from sorrow. “Rise and pray that you may not enter into temptation.” The Son does what Adam did not: he submits to the will of the Father.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 12 is the Passover. Jeremiah 31:31-34 promises the new covenant. Isaiah 53:12 says he poured out his soul to death. 1 Corinthians 11:23-26 is Paul’s account of the Supper. Hebrews 5:7-8 describes the prayers and cries of Jesus. Mark 10:42-45 is the parallel on servant

leadership. John 13:1-17 shows Jesus washing the disciples' feet. 1 Peter 5:8 warns that the devil prowls like a roaring lion.

STEP 6

Application

When you receive the Lord's Supper, think about each word: broken for you, poured out for you.

Practice the service of the one who serves. Do something humble for someone today, unseen if possible.

Pray Jesus' prayer in your hardest decision: "Not my will, but yours."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for the Passover he earnestly desired to eat with his disciples.
- Tell him about the cup you are afraid to drink, and pray, "Not my will but yours."
- Ask him to help you stay awake and pray.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 90

"This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me."

LUKE 22:19

DAY 629 · WEEK 90

Luke 22:47-23:25

Arrest; trials; Peter's denial; before Pilate and Herod

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 50 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 22:47-23:25. The arrest, Peter's denial, the mockery, and the trials before the council, Pilate, and Herod. Notice how many times Jesus is declared innocent.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Judas arrives with a crowd, and Jesus is arrested at night. He is taken to the high priest's house while Peter follows at a distance. Before dawn he stands before the council, then before Pilate, the Roman governor, then Herod Antipas, and again Pilate. Luke stresses that Jesus is innocent. Pilate says so three times, and Herod finds nothing worthy of death.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Judas, would you betray the Son of Man with a kiss?" (22:48).
2. "But this is your hour, and the power of darkness" (22:53).
3. "And the Lord turned and looked at Peter. And Peter remembered the saying of the Lord" (22:61).
4. "And he went out and wept bitterly" (22:62).
5. "You say that I am" (22:70).
6. "I find no guilt in this man" (23:4).
7. "Why? What evil has he done? I have found in him no guilt deserving death" (23:22).
8. "But he delivered Jesus over to their will" (23:25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus is arrested in the garden. A disciple cuts off the ear of the high priest's servant, and Jesus says, "No more of this!" and heals the ear. This is the last healing Luke records, and it is for one of those arresting him. Jesus tells the crowd, "This is your hour, and the power of darkness." Everything is happening by God's plan, yet the guilt is real.

Peter follows at a distance, and in the courtyard denies knowing Jesus three times. Then the rooster crows, and "the Lord turned and looked at Peter." Only Luke tells us this. In that look Peter remembered, "and he went out and wept bitterly." The look was not condemnation but love. Jesus had prayed for Peter, and the prayer was working.

Jesus is mocked and beaten. At dawn the council asks if he is the Christ, and he replies, "From now on the Son of Man shall be seated at the right hand of the power of God." They ask, "Are you the Son of God?" and he says, "You say that I am." They have what they want.

They take him to Pilate and accuse him of misleading the nation, forbidding tribute to Caesar, and claiming to be a king. Pilate asks if he is the King of the Jews and then declares, "I find no guilt in this man." When he learns Jesus is a Galilean, he sends him to Herod, who has wanted to see him for a long time and hopes for a sign. Jesus is silent. Herod and his soldiers mock him and send him back. "That same day Herod and Pilate became friends." The powers of the world unite against the Son of God.

Pilate tries three times to release him. "I have found in him no guilt deserving death." But the crowd shouts, "Crucify him!" and asks for Barabbas, a murderer. Pilate gives in. "He delivered Jesus over to their will." An innocent man took the place of a guilty one. Barabbas is a picture of every sinner: set free because Jesus stood in his place.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 53:7 says he opened not his mouth. Psalm 41:9 and 55:12-14 describe betrayal by a friend. Zechariah 13:7 foretold the striking of the shepherd. Isaiah 50:6 describes the servant who gave his back to those who strike. Psalm 2:1-2 describes the rulers gathering against the LORD and his anointed. Acts 4:25-28 applies that psalm to Herod and Pilate. 1 Peter 2:22-24 says he committed no sin and bore our sins in his body.

STEP 6

Application

Consider Peter. Have you denied Jesus in word or silence? Let his look of love meet you, and weep as Peter did.

Notice how the innocent one is silent. Where do you need to hold your tongue?

Thank Jesus for being your Barabbas substitute.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for being betrayed, denied, and mocked for you.

Confess where you have denied him.

Thank him that he looked at Peter, and ask him to look at you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 90

“This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me.”

LUKE 22:19

DAY 630 · WEEK 90

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Luke 22:19 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me."

LUKE 22:19

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this at the table on the night before his death. He takes the Passover bread, gives thanks, breaks it, and gives it to his disciples. In a few hours he will be arrested, and he knows it.

"This is my body." At the Passover, Israel ate bread and remembered the exodus. Jesus takes the bread of that meal and attaches it to himself. His body will be broken, and the true exodus from sin and death will come through him. Christians have understood the exact nature of the bread in different ways, but all hold that this meal is about Christ.

"Which is given for you." The word "for" is the heart of the gospel. He is not simply a martyr or an example. His body is given in your place, on your behalf. And it is personal: for you.

"Do this." Jesus gives a command. The Lord's Supper is not optional for the church. It is a gift and an instruction, and it has been kept for two thousand years.

“In remembrance of me.” To remember in the Bible is more than recalling a fact. It is to bring the past into the present, to be fed by it, and to proclaim it. When we take the bread and the cup, we look back to the cross, look up to the risen Christ, and look forward to the day he comes again.

When you doubt that you are loved, say this verse. His body was given for you.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read Psalm 31:19-24, where the goodness of God is stored up for those who fear him, and Psalm 41 and Psalm 55, where David’s own friend lifted his heel against him, and where he learned to cast his burden on the LORD. In Luke 19 to 21 the King rode into Jerusalem, wept over it, cleansed the temple, and silenced every question. He praised a poor widow and spoke of his return. In Luke 22 and 23 you came to the upper room, where Jesus gave the bread and the cup of the new covenant, and to Gethsemane, where he prayed, “Not my will, but yours.” You watched him be betrayed with a kiss, denied by Peter, mocked, declared innocent three times, and handed over to the crowd in place of Barabbas.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus said his body was given “for you” and his blood poured out for you. What does it mean to you personally that he did this?

In Gethsemane, Jesus prayed, “Not my will, but yours, be done.” How does his submission to the Father shape the way you pray when you face something hard?

Peter denied Jesus, and Jesus looked at him. Where do you need to receive that look of love, rather than of condemnation?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Remember Jesus with the bread and the cup, in your own words.

Thank him for his body given and his blood poured out.

Rest in what he did.

DAY 631 · WEEK 91

Luke 23:26-56

The crucifixion, "Father, forgive them"; the burial

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 31 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 23:26-56. The road to the cross, the crucifixion, two criminals, the death of Jesus, and his burial. This is the center of the Gospel. Read slowly and in silence if you can.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus is led out of Jerusalem to a place called The Skull, carrying his cross, and a bystander, Simon of Cyrene, is forced to carry it for him. A great crowd follows, including women who mourn. Luke's account is marked by mercy. Even on the cross, Jesus forgives his killers and promises paradise to a dying criminal.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Daughters of Jerusalem, do not weep for me, but weep for yourselves and for your children" (23:28).
2. "Father, forgive them, for they know not what they do" (23:34).
3. "He saved others; let him save himself, if he is the Christ of God, his Chosen One!" (23:35).
4. "Jesus, remember me when you come into your kingdom" (23:42).
5. "Truly, I say to you, today you will be with me in paradise" (23:43).
6. "And the curtain of the temple was torn in two" (23:45).
7. "Father, into your hands I commit my spirit!" (23:46).
8. "Now there was a man named Joseph… a good and righteous man" (23:50).

STEP 4

Interpretation

On the way, Jesus turns to the weeping women and tells them to weep for themselves and for their children. He is thinking of Jerusalem's coming judgment. Even on his way to die, he cares for others.

At the cross, they crucify him between two criminals. His first words in Luke's account are a prayer: "Father, forgive them, for they know not what they do." This is the opposite of what any of us would pray. The soldiers divide his garments by lot, the rulers sneer, the soldiers mock him, and a sign over his head reads, "This is the King of the Jews." The mockers say, "Save yourself." They don't realize that he is saving others precisely by not saving himself.

One criminal joins the mockery. The other rebukes him: "Do you not fear God?" He acknowledges that they are justly condemned, but this man has done nothing wrong. Then he says, "Jesus, remember me when you come into your kingdom." This is faith in its barest form. He has no good works, no time to be baptized, and no way to make amends. He asks only to be remembered. And Jesus answers, "Today you will be with me in paradise." This is the gospel in a sentence: salvation by grace through faith, immediately, for a dying thief.

Darkness covers the land for three hours, and the curtain of the temple tears in two. The way into the presence of God is now open through the death of Jesus. Then he cries with a loud voice, "Father, into your hands I commit my spirit!" He quotes Psalm 31:5, which you prayed on Day 619, and breathes his last. He does not lose his life. He gives it. The centurion praises God and says, "Certainly this man was innocent!" The crowds go home beating their breasts.

Joseph of Arimathea, a member of the council who had not consented to the plan, asks for the body and lays it in a new tomb. The women from Galilee see where it is laid, prepare spices, and rest on the Sabbath according to the commandment. The body is in the tomb. Everything depends on what happens next.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 53:4-12 describes the servant who bore our griefs, was numbered with the transgressors, and made intercession. Psalm 22 begins with the cry of forsakenness and ends in praise. Psalm 31:5 is the prayer Jesus prays. Exodus 26:31-33 describes the curtain before the Holy of Holies. Hebrews 10:19-22 says we have confidence to enter the holy places by the blood of Jesus. Romans 5:8 shows his love for sinners. Acts 7:60 has Stephen echoing the prayer for forgiveness.

STEP 6

Application

Sit with the cross for ten minutes in silence. Do not rush to the resurrection.

Pray the thief's prayer: "Jesus, remember me." It is enough.

Forgive someone as Jesus forgave. If you can't yet, ask him for the willingness.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for praying, "Father, forgive them," and ask him to forgive you.
- Pray the thief's prayer: "Jesus, remember me."
- Thank him for the promise of paradise.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 91

"And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth."

JOHN 1:14

DAY 632 · WEEK 91

Luke 24:1-53

The resurrection; Emmaus; the ascension

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 53 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 24:1-53. The empty tomb, the road to Emmaus, the appearance to the disciples, and the ascension. This is the climax of the Gospel and the key to reading the whole Bible.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

On the first day of the week, at early dawn, the women come to the tomb with spices. The disciples are scattered and afraid. Luke's last chapter takes place in a single day: the morning at the tomb, the afternoon on the road to Emmaus, and the evening in Jerusalem. It ends with the ascension, and leads straight into the book of Acts.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Why do you seek the living among the dead? He is not here, but has risen" (24:5-6).
2. "But we had hoped that he was the one to redeem Israel" (24:21).
3. "O foolish ones, and slow of heart to believe all that the prophets have spoken!" (24:25).
4. "And beginning with Moses and all the Prophets, he interpreted to them in all the Scriptures the things concerning himself" (24:27).
5. "Did not our hearts burn within us while he talked to us on the road, while he opened to us the Scriptures?" (24:32).
6. "See my hands and my feet, that it is I myself. Touch me, and see" (24:39).
7. "Thus it is written, that the Christ should suffer and on the third day rise from the dead, and that repentance for the forgiveness of sins should be proclaimed in his name to all nations" (24:46-47).

8 “And they worshiped him and returned to Jerusalem with great joy” (24:52).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The women find the stone rolled away and the tomb empty. Two men in dazzling clothes say, “Why do you seek the living among the dead? He is not here, but has risen.” They remind the women of what Jesus said in Galilee. The women tell the apostles, but the words seem to them an idle tale, and they do not believe. Peter runs to the tomb, sees the linen cloths, and goes home marveling.

That afternoon, two disciples walk to Emmaus, discussing the events. A stranger joins them, and they do not recognize him. He asks what they are talking about, and they stand still, looking sad. “We had hoped that he was the one to redeem Israel.” Their hope was crushed. The stranger replies, “O foolish ones, and slow of heart to believe all that the prophets have spoken! Was it not necessary that the Christ should suffer these things and enter into his glory?” And “beginning with Moses and all the Prophets, he interpreted to them in all the Scriptures the things concerning himself.”

This is the key to reading the whole Bible. All of Scripture, from Moses to the Prophets, points to Christ: his sufferings and his glory. The Old Testament is not a collection of unrelated stories. It is a single story that leads to him. This is the reason the Old Testament is read with the cross in view. At supper, in the breaking of the bread, their eyes were opened and they recognized him, and he vanished. “Did not our hearts burn within us while he talked to us on the road, while he opened to us the Scriptures?” They returned to Jerusalem the same hour.

While they are telling the others, Jesus himself stands among them and says, “Peace to you!” They think he is a ghost, and he shows them his hands and feet and eats a piece of broiled fish. The resurrection was bodily. Then he opens their minds to understand the Scriptures and says that everything written about him in the Law, the Prophets, and the Psalms must be fulfilled. The Christ suffers and rises, and repentance and forgiveness of sins are to be proclaimed in his name to all nations, beginning from Jerusalem. “You are witnesses of these things.” He promises the gift of the Holy Spirit, “the promise of my Father.”

He leads them out to Bethany, lifts up his hands, blesses them, and is carried up into heaven. They worship him and return to Jerusalem with great joy, continually in the temple blessing God. The Gospel that began in the temple with a priest who was struck silent ends in the temple with a people full of praise.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 53 and Psalm 22 are among the passages about the suffering and glory of the Christ. Genesis 3:15, Deuteronomy 18:15, 2 Samuel 7, and Psalm 110 are all part of the testimony. Acts 1:1-11 continues the story. 1 Corinthians 15:3-8 lists the appearances of the risen Christ. John 20:19-29 gives the parallel appearances. 2 Timothy 3:15 says the Scriptures are able to make you wise for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus. Hebrews 1:1-2 says God has spoken by his Son.

STEP 6

Application

Think of an Old Testament passage you have loved, and ask: where does it point to Christ?

When you feel your hopes are crushed, remember that the stranger on the road was alive.

Ask the Lord to open the Scriptures to you, so that your heart burns as you read.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus that he is alive, and walks with the discouraged.
- Ask him to open your mind to understand the Scriptures.
- Ask him to make your heart burn as you read.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 91

"And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth."

JOHN 1:14

DAY 633 · WEEK 91

Review and Reflection

Unit 16 review, The New Covenant Inaugurated, Luke

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost."
>
> LUKE 19:10

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this to the crowd that grumbled that he had gone to be the guest of a sinner. Zacchaeus has just given half his goods to the poor, and Jesus replies with his own mission statement.

"For the Son of Man." This is Jesus' favorite title for himself. It comes from Daniel 7, the one who receives dominion from the Ancient of Days, and it also speaks of his humanity. He is the glorious King and the humble servant.

"Came." He came on purpose. Salvation is not a rescue improvised in an emergency. The Son came from the Father with a mission, and Luke has shown it from the manger to the empty tomb.

"To seek." God is the one who seeks. In Luke 15 the shepherd goes after the sheep, the woman searches for the coin, and the father watches the road. Christianity is not a story of humans reaching up for God but of God reaching down. Even our seeking is a response to being sought.

"And to save." The seeking has a purpose, and the purpose is rescue. He came to give his life as a ransom, as he showed on the cross.

"The lost." That is who he seeks. Not the confident or the righteous in their own eyes, but those who know they are lost, like Zacchaeus in his tree, the thief on the cross, the prodigal in the pigsty, and you.

When you feel too far gone, say this verse. You are exactly who he came for.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

You have read the whole Gospel of Luke, and the thread running through it is that salvation is for everyone, including those the world overlooks. It opens with songs: Mary's Magnificat, in which God lifts up the lowly and sends the rich away empty, and Zechariah's Benedictus, which celebrates a God who keeps his covenant. The Savior is born in a manger, announced first to shepherds, and welcomed by Simeon and Anna as a light for the Gentiles. In Nazareth he reads Isaiah 61 and declares that the Scripture is fulfilled in him. He is filled with the Holy Spirit, and he prays at every turning point, before his baptism, before choosing the Twelve, on the mountain, and in the garden. He eats with sinners, honors a centurion's faith, and forgives a woman who loves much. On the road to Jerusalem he teaches the parables found only in Luke: the Good Samaritan, the rich fool, the lost sheep, the lost coin, the lost son, Lazarus, the Pharisee and the tax collector. He meets Zacchaeus and says that he came to seek and save the lost. In Jerusalem he institutes the new covenant in his blood, prays in Gethsemane, is betrayed and denied, declared innocent, and crucified. He forgives his killers, promises paradise to a thief, and commits his spirit to the Father. On the third day he rises and walks with two discouraged disciples, opening to them all the Scriptures concerning himself. The Gospel ends with the commission to preach repentance and forgiveness to all nations, and the promise of the Spirit. Along the way you also prayed Psalms 113, 116, 117, 27, 28, 31, 41, and 55, which gave words to the praise, trust, and betrayal in the story.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What does the Magnificat reveal about the kind of salvation God brings?

Reread Luke 1:46-55 and Psalm 113. Notice the reversal of the proud and the lowly, and the link to the promise made to Abraham. Write a few sentences about how this song sets the tone for the whole Gospel.

How does Luke emphasize the role of the Holy Spirit?

Think of the Spirit's presence at John's birth, Mary's conception, Jesus' baptism, the wilderness, Nazareth, and the promise of the Father in chapter 24. What difference does the Spirit make in Jesus' life, and what does he promise for his followers?

What does Luke's emphasis on prayer teach us about Jesus' own spiritual life?

Recall the times Jesus prayed: at his baptism, before choosing the Twelve, in desolate places, on the mountain, in Gethsemane, and on the cross. Pick one and describe what it shows about his dependence on the Father and what it means for your own prayer.

How does the road to Emmaus teach us how to read the whole Bible?

Reread Luke 24:25-27 and 24:44-47. Jesus says that Moses, the Prophets, and the Psalms are about him. Name one Old Testament passage from this plan that you now read differently because of this, and explain how it points to Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for sending his Son to seek and save the lost, and for finding you.

Tell him what you have seen in Jesus through Luke.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.